HT MUMBAI, NEW DELHI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, CHENNAI, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE*

Thursday, March 12, 2026

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Street sinks as swift revival hopes fade ▶P1

Young savers drift away as retirees prop up deposits ▶P1

CENTRAL RAILWAY

SOLAPUR DIVISION

ELECTRICAL WORK

The Senior Divisional Electrical Engineer (TRD), Central Railway, Solapur, for and on behalf of the President of India invites online e-tenders on Railways e-procurement website **www.ireps.gov.in** from reputed, experienced & licensed Electrical contractors for the following works: **Tender No.:** SUR/TD/T/2025/23R1. **Name of work:** Electrical TRD portion of work in connection with provision of one long-haul loop line in each direction at Malthan station in Daund-Solapur section of Solapur Division, (Re-invitation). **Estimated cost:** ₹ 1,22,40,703.62. **Bid Security:** ₹ 2,11,200/-, **Completion period:** 12 months. **Validity of offer:** 60 Days. **Date & time of tender closing on website:** 07.04.2026 at 15.00 hours. EXP-10

Download RailOne App for Tickets

Canara HSBC LIFE INSURANCE

Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company Limited
139, Sector - 44, Gurugram-122003, Haryana (India)
Tel: 0124-4535500, Email: procurement@canarahsbclife.in

NOTICE INVITING BIDS/OFFERS

Open Tender is invited against **RFP for AWS Private Pricing and discounting on overall billing dated 12th March 2026.**

Above tender has been uploaded on **https://www.canarahsbclife.com/tenders-notices.html**, website of Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company Ltd. All prospective bidders are advised to visit the aforesaid website for downloading the RFP.

BRIHANMUMBAI MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT DEPARTMENT (PLANNING)

No. Dy. Ch. E./9509/SWM/ Planning dtd. 11.03.2026

e-Tender Notice

Subject	:	"Supply of yellow bags for collection of domestic sanitary waste and special care waste in western suburb region"
Department	:	Solid Waste Management / Dy.Ch.Eng.(SWM)Planning
Tender ID No.	:	2026_MCGM_1285862_1
Bid Start Date & Time	:	12.03.2026 from 11:00 AM
Bid End Date & Time	:	16.03.2026 till 16.00 PM
Website	:	**https://mahatenders.gov.in**
Contact Person:-		
a) Name	:	Shri Hemant Bhusare, AE (SWM) Planning
b)Telephone	:	022-23844450
c) Mobile No.	:	9762006449
d) E-mail Id	:	**ee1swm.pl@mcgm.gov.in**

PRO/3259/ADV/2025-26 **Sd/-**

AVOID SELF MEDICATION **Ex. Eng. (SWM) Planning**

WEST BENGAL STATE ELECTRICITY DISTRIBUTION COMPANY LIMITED

(A Govt. of West Bengal Enterprise)

Regd. Office : Vidyut Bhavan, Block-DJ, Sector-II, Bidhannagar, Kolkata - 700 091
CIN : U40109WB2007SGC113473, www.wbsedcl.in

WBSEDCL

Extension(s) of Time

Ref. Original **NIT No.:** WBSEDCL/SPGD/100 MW/Goaltore Phase-II/2025-26/NIT-84, **Dated:** 05.02.2026 of the **Chief Engineer, Solar Power Generation Department. Bid Submission (only through Exfitender) Date** extended up to: **02.04.2026 (05:00 PM IST/11:30 PM UTC).**

ICA- T6863(3)/2026

For details, visit **www.exfitender.de** & **www.wbsedcl.in**

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of

HT **TWTW**
THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

HT FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

hindustantimes htTweets www.hindustantimes.com

BRIHANMUMBAI MUNICIPAL CORPORATION

TREE AUTHORITY

-PUBLIC NOTICE-

In accordance with the provision under section 8 (3) (C) of the Maharashtra (Urban Areas) Protection & Preservation of Trees Act 1975 (As modified upto 24th January 2021) **01** proposal from **K/South** Ward & **01** Proposal from **H/East** Ward in **Zone-III** Total **02** proposals are received for getting approval of Municipal Commissioner /Chairman. Tree Authority for removal of trees under section 8 (6) of the Maharashtra (Urban Areas) Protection & Preservation of Trees Act 1975. (As modified upto 24th Jan 2021).

The information of the trees for cutting / Transplanting in above mentioned proposals is available on BMC website ----> **www.mcgm.gov.in.** ----> About us ----> ward / Department ----> Department manuals ----> Gardens & Tree Authority ----> Docs ----> Tree Permission 21 Days.----> 471 (K/South), 472 (H/East) -Zone -3.

Supdt.of Gardens & Tree officer of the Tree Authority
Office of the Supdt. Of Gardens & Tree Officers
2nd Floor, Humboldt Penguin Bldg.,
Veermata Jijabai Bhosale Udyan & Zoo,
Sant Savata Mali Marg, Byculla (E), Mumbai-400 027
Tel. No. 23742162
Email - dysg.ta@mcgm.gov.in

PRO/3248/ADV/2025-26 **Sd/-**

AVOID SELF MEDICATION **Supdt. Of Gardens & Tree Officer**

HT MUMBAI, NEW DELHI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, CHENNAI, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE* VOL. 9 NO. 61

Thursday, March 12, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Is govt's order to divert gas open to legal challenge?

KRISHNA YADAV

The West Asia war has sparked a crunch in gas supply. The Centre has set out gas use priorities in an order, which also discourages firms receiving pooled gas from legally challenging its decision. *Mint* explains the order, and whether courts can still entertain challenges.


AFP

1 What exactly did the government order?

The order introduced a four-tier priority framework for allocating natural gas. It gives top priority to piped gas for households, CNG for transport, LPG production, and essential pipeline operations. Fertilizer plants fall under the second-priority, while other industrial sectors are placed lower. To ensure adequate supply to priority sectors, the government may cut gas supplies to industries such as petrochemicals, power plants and refineries. The notification also contains a clause that requires companies receiving pooled gas to undertake that they won't challenge the revised supply arrangement.

2 What is the Essential Commodities Act?

The 1955 legislation allows the Indian government to regulate the production, supply and distribution of essential goods to ensure availability and prevent hoarding and black marketing. The law was enacted at a time when India faced severe shortages of food grains and other essential goods. The law was amended in 2020, reducing routine government control over agricultural commodities. Regulation and stock limits on cereals, pulses, potatoes, onions, edible oilseeds, and oils can now be imposed only in extraordinary situations like war, famine, natural calamity, or sharp price rises.

REUTERS

3 When was this law used recently?

The Act has been mostly used to address shortages and price spikes in food and medical supplies. During covid, masks and hand sanitizers were declared essential commodities to prevent hoarding and price gouging. The Centre also used the law in recent years to impose stock limits on pulses, edible oils and onions when prices rose sharply.

4 Does it bar courts from hearing challenges?

Legal experts said the notification discourages litigation but does not completely block judicial scrutiny. Chirag Gupta, associate partner at Alpha Partners, said the restriction mainly applies to companies that receive pooled gas supplies. "The direction issued only applies to the entities to whom pooled gas is being diverted," he said. Affected companies can still approach constitutional courts. Companies can challenge the order by moving high courts under Article 226 or the Supreme Court under Article 32.

5 What other legal options exist?

Experts said companies may explore contractual remedies depending on their agreements. Varun Lakra, associate partner at King Stubb & Kasiva, said the order overrides existing gas sale agreements. "This means contractual obligations may be temporarily superseded where government-mandated diversion of gas is required," he said. Companies may still look at provisions such as force majeure clauses or arbitration, although the scope of such remedies could be limited.

mint | DATA BITES

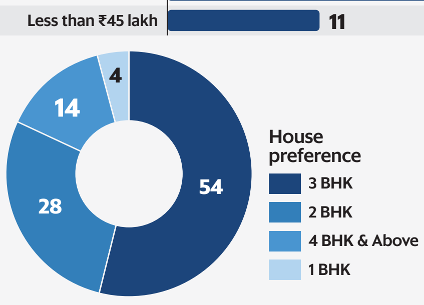
WHAT DEFINES A WOMAN'S DREAM HOME?

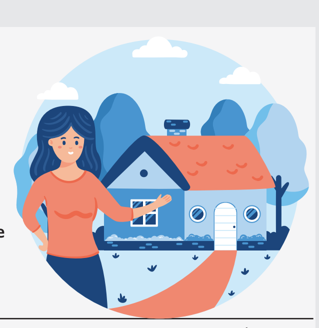
About 60% of aspiring women homebuyers prefer properties above ₹90 lakh, with 37% eyeing the ₹90 lakh to ₹1.5 crore segment, as per an Anarock survey. More than half of them prefer three-bedroom homes.

Share (%) of aspiring women homebuyers who prefer the following

Price preference

Price preference	Share (%)
More than ₹2.5 crore	10
₹1.5 crore–₹2.5 crore	14
₹90 lakh–₹1.5 crore	37
₹45 lakh–₹90 lakh	28
Less than ₹45 lakh	11





The survey covered 4,900 women participants.

Data: Rupanjal Chauhan; Graphic: Manu Choudhary

Source: Anarock Group

QUICK EDIT

Reliance in the US

Springing a surprise, US President Donald Trump on Wednesday announced a plan for what he called America's first new refinery in half-a-century, backed by investment from India's Reliance. To be built by America First Refining, it is part of a deal whose value Trump put at $300 billion, calling it the biggest in US history. "Thank you to our partners in India, and their largest privately held Energy Company, Reliance, for this tremendous Investment," he said in a Truth Social post. The exact details of the project are unclear as of now. Still, Trump's exuberance is a sharp contrast from his administration's past denunciation of India's "energy titans" for allegedly supporting Russia's war machine by buying oil from it. News of the project also suggests that an Indian promise to invest large sums in the United States, if this is indeed made part of a bilateral trade deal, may not be all that hard to meet. Of course, the big round numbers that Trump has been citing in this context may just be indicative. But if the refinery comes up, Trump could claim a victory for "America First" while Reliance seeks to make the most of America's shale oil revolution.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

Today, we have the capability to conceive, design, and build our own launch vehicles, as well as conceive, build, and place satellites in orbit... Today, we can build satellites and the payloads required for them.

V. NARAYANAN
CHAIRMAN, ISRO

INSIDE

Q A with mint

EDITOR'S NOTE

Dear Subscriber,

I have a request. We want to understand your needs better so we can tailor our offerings to better serve you. We have prepared a short interview that will help us know your expectations from us better. Go to *https://bit.ly/mintsurvey2026* or scan this QR code. It takes less than 10 minutes. If you would like to share thoughts, ideas or feedback, please write to feedback@livemint.com. Looking forward to your response.

Sincerely,
— Ravi Krishnan
Editor-in-Chief

mint

PLAIN FACTS

VIETNAM LEADS EMs, INDIA AT RANK FIVE

BY PAYAL BHATTACHARYA

India's standing among traditional emerging market (EM) peers has been strong due to its robust GDP growth. The country now faces challenges from Vietnam's rapidly rising status and its own external weaknesses.

EMERGING MARKETS TRACKER

Launched in September 2019, *Mint's* Emerging Markets Tracker provides a summary of economic activity across 12 large emerging markets based on seven high-frequency indicators. Vietnam has secured the first position in January 2026, while South Africa is at the second position. Malaysia moved up one place to the third rank.

Better performance

Country	Composite index score, latest	Real GDP growth (y-o-y, in %)	PMI manufacturing	Export growth (y-o-y, in %)	CPI inflation (y-o-y, in %)	Import cover (no. of months)	Exchange rate movement* (m-o-m, in %)	Stock market capitalization* (m-o-m, in %)
VIETNAM	82.3	8.0	52.5	30.1	2.0	18.2	0.4	9.9
SOUTH AFRICA	59.3	2.1	48.7	19.8	0.5	6.8	3.4	8.6
MALAYSIA	58.8	6.3	50.2	19.6	0.3	4.1	1.5	5.0
CHINA	57.6	4.5	49.3	6.6	1.8	15.8	1.1	8.2
INDIA	**51.4**	7.8	55.4	0.6	1.3	11.6	-0.9	-1.8
THAILAND	50.9	2.5	52.7	24.9	2.7	9.5	0.9	2.3
BRAZIL	48.6	1.8	47.0	-1.0	1.4	17.5	2.0	7.0
RUSSIA	47.2	1.9	49.4	9.8	6.0	18.5	0.6	10.0
PHILIPPINES	46.8	3.0	52.9	7.9	1.0	10.1	-0.5	3.6
INDONESIA	44.5	5.4	52.6	3.4	1.1	7.7	-0.7	1.5
MEXICO	39.4	1.6	46.3	8.1	0.8	4.6	2.6	4.4
TURKEY	18.2	3.7	48.1	-4	6.7	2.8	-1.3	7.1

Scoring method: The best-performing economy's value on any given indicator gets a score of 100, the worst one gets zero, and the rest are interpolated linearly for their relative scores. Scores for inflation for each country have been assigned based on the magnitude of deviation from the respective central bank target (mid-point in case of ranges). A country's composite index score is the simple average of its seven indicator scores. Latest available data used (as of 11 March 2026). Scores/ranks may change as more data comes in. *Change in monthly average. Exchange rate is against US dollar.

Source: Bloomberg, Mint calculations

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SATISH KUMAR/MINT

If gross domestic product (GDP) growth, manufacturing activity, contained inflation and a comfortable import cover are India's strengths, the rupee and stock markets are proving to be its Achilles' heel.

These external vulnerabilities have repeatedly prevented India from topping *Mint*'s Emerging Markets Tracker more consistently. As the country grapples with these weaknesses, Vietnam—newly-added to the tracker—has emerged as a strong challenger.

Vietnam has topped the tracker in three of the past four months, making a strong debut. Over a longer 12-month horizon, however, India retains a narrow lead: it ranked first six times compared with Vietnam's five.

The contest between India—an established EM giant—and Vietnam—an increasingly prominent emerging economy—has, therefore, become one of the most closely-watched dynamics in the tracker.

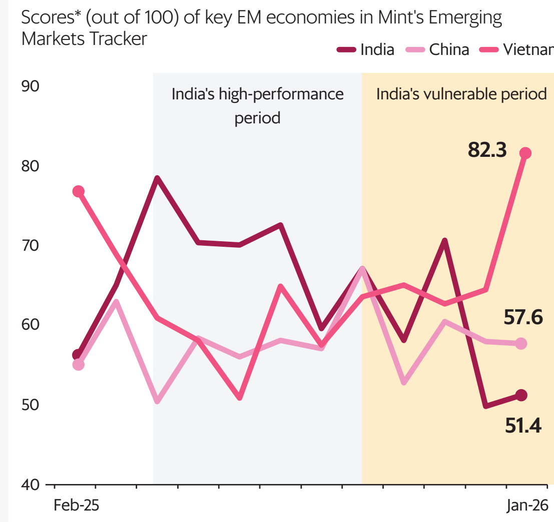
Launched in September 2019, *Mint*'s Emerging Markets Tracker compares major emerging economies using seven high-frequency indicators: real GDP growth, manufacturing PMI, export growth, retail inflation, import cover, exchange rate movements and stock market performance.

Originally tracking 10 EM economies, the index now includes Vietnam and South Africa, taking the total to 12, and broadening the framework to better capture shifts in the emerging market landscape.

The rankings in this analysis map the performance of these economies based on the updated tracker over the past 12 months.

India's weaknesses opened the door for Vietnam to take a solid lead in EM tracker

Scores* (out of 100) of key EM economies in Mint's Emerging Markets Tracker



*Based on the relative performances of twelve countries on seven indicators.

Source: Bloomberg, Mint calculations

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PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

JANUARY GAUGE

A 0.9% sequential decline in the rupee and a 1.79% month-on-month fall in stock market capitalization kept India at fifth place in January. Its stock market performance was the worst during the month, while the rupee was the second-worst among the 12 EM peers.

Despite the setback, India has partially recovered from its December 2025 low of ninth place.

Vietnam, in contrast, retained strong momentum. Economy grew 8.0%, exports rose 30%, and stock market capitalization increased 9.9%. The Vietnamese currency appreciated 0.4% against the dollar, though the gain was modest compared with several other emerging markets.

South Africa, Malaysia, and China also ranked ahead of India in January, taking the second, third and fourth spots, respectively, though none have been as consistent a contender as Vietnam for the top spot.

India has faced multiple headwinds since at least August 2025 that have weighed on the rupee and equity markets. These include Washington's 25% additional penalty on purchases of Russian oil, stock market valuation concerns, weak earnings, and slow nominal GDP growth.

The outlook is uncertain as geopolitical tensions in West Asia threaten to intensify India's external vulnerabilities.

FUTURE RISKS

Escalating tension in West Asia, with Iran's retaliation choking oil and gas supplies from Gulf countries, threatens to further erode India's external position.

The rupee has crossed the 92-dollar mark, weakening 1.4-1.5% from average January levels. Brent topped $100 per barrel before settling around $90, still up 30% so far this year. Economists estimate that every 10% rise in crude worsens India's current account deficit as percentage of GDP by about 40 basis points, lifts inflation by 30-50 basis points, and trims GDP growth by 15 basis points.

India is not alone. The conflict could shave off 40-80 basis points from Vietnam's GDP growth and cut exports by 2-5%. Heavily dependent on West Asia for energy, both countries are scrambling to manage potential fuel shortages.

India has restricted gas supply to industrial and commercial sectors, while Vietnam has advised businesses to allow employees to work from home to reduce fuel consumption. Several other emerging markets are also taking, or considering, similar steps.

A Nomura report on 1 March flagged Thailand, India, Indonesia, and the Philippines as among the Asian emerging markets most vulnerable to the Iran war. China has also asked companies to curb diesel and gasoline exports to prioritize domestic energy security.

INDIA VS VIETNAM VS CHINA

After decades of stellar growth, China has slowed amid weak domestic consumption. It is now targeting a 4.5-5% growth, compared with about 5% in the preceding three years and 6-6.5% or higher earlier.

Despite its unmatched dominance in GDP and trade, China's shift from high-speed to high-quality growth has made it a middling performer on the tracker. India ranked first or second between March 2025 and September 2025, before external vulnerabilities caught up, leaving it struggling to hold the top spot.

Vietnam, by contrast, has maintained 7-8% GDP expansion, double-digit export growth, strong manufacturing, and volatile, but broadly supportive, currency and stock market performance, making it a credible contender.

To be sure, Vietnam remains a small economy, about one-eighth the size of India and a fraction of China, but its rapidly rising profile, particularly as an alternative investment destination to Beijing, is worth watching.

HT MUMBAI, NEW DELHI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, CHENNAI, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE* VOL. 9 NO. 61 Rs. 12.00 18 PAGES

Thursday, March 12, 2026

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A new chapter opens for books in India

▶P10

KKR eyes platforms for renewable assets in India

▶P3

SENSEX 76,863.69 ↓ 1,342.29 NIFTY 23,866.85 ↓ 394.75 DOLLAR ₹92.01 ↑ ₹0.16 EURO ₹106.69 ↑ ₹0.28 OIL $89.71 ↓ $0.77 POUND ₹123.49 ↑ ₹0.08

Street sinks as swift revival hopes fade

Markets fall over 1.6% as renewed uncertainty sparks selling

Dipti Sharma
dipti.sharma@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Indian equity markets started Wednesday on a cautious footing, but the mood quickly turned sour as a broad-based sell-off gathered pace. Benchmark indices fell nearly 2%, closing at a 10-month low, quickly erasing the optimism seen in the previous session.

Early hopes that tensions in West Asia might cool soon faded as reports of fresh military activity surfaced and concerns about a protracted closure of Strait of Hormuz returned. The sell-off wiped out ₹5.48 trillion in BSE market capitalization in a single session. Since the West Asia war began, BSE-listed companies have now seen nearly ₹21.95 trillion of investor wealth evaporate, underscoring the turmoil's toll on the markets.

The Nifty closed 1.63% lower at 23,866.85, and the Sensex ended down 1.72% at 76,863.71. However, losses in the broader market were comparatively lower, with the Nifty Midcap 100 and Nifty Smallcap 250 falling 1.3% and 0.4%, respectively, suggesting bargain hunting. The market's fear gauge India Vix jumped over 11%, reflecting investor anxiety.

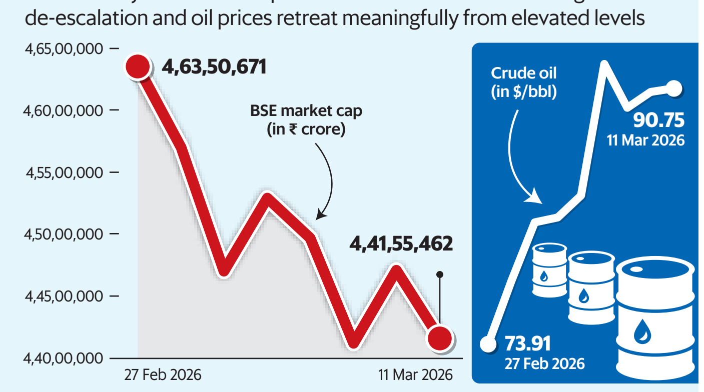
"Equity markets tend to reprice swiftly in response, particularly in oil-sensitive sectors such as aviation, paints, cement, and chemicals," said Devarsh Vakil, head of Prime Research, HDFC Securities.

Indian markets are likely to remain under pressure until there are credible signs of de-escalation and crude oil prices retreat meaningfully from elevated levels, he added. If this proves to be a temporary disruption, companies may absorb its impact, but if the war lasts beyond a few weeks, it will pose a

TURN TO PAGE 6

FALL SEASON

Markets may remain under pressure until there are credible signs of de-escalation and oil prices retreat meaningfully from elevated levels



Source: Bloomberg

WAR WOES

FEAR index jumps 11%, investors move to defensive stance

M-CAP of listed firms down nearly ₹22 tn since the start of war

HIGHER oil prices are squeezing margins across sectors

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

Young savers drift away as retirees prop up deposits

Shayan Ghosh
shayan.g@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Indian banks are losing ground among working-age savers, even as retirees return in growing numbers to park money in fixed deposits and savings accounts.

Recent data from the Reserve Bank of India shows the share of deposits held by working Indians aged 25 to less than 60 has steadily declined over the past two years, highlighting how younger savers are no longer reliant on banks to grow their money.

The working population held 55.46% of retail deposits in December 2025, down from 57.41% in March 2023, the earliest comparable data. That is a change of 195 basis points (bps).

By contrast, the share of depositors aged 60 and above rose to 40.6% from 38.25% as of March 2023, up 235 bps. Given that the retail deposit base is ₹124.7 trillion, every 100 bps is worth ₹1.2 trillion.

Armed with sovereign backing and a public image of strength, India's public sector banks have traditionally depended on customers walking up to the branches to deposit money. That changed with the advent of savvier private banks quick to pull customers rather than wait for them to show up. That said, the war for deposits has wounded every lender, irrespective of ownership.

"There is a generational shift," said Bhavik Hathi, managing director, Alvarez & Marsal. "The working population, especially those in the age group of 25 to 40, are more aware of alternative investment options."

Hathi said that there is greater general awareness, access to alternative investments that generally yield

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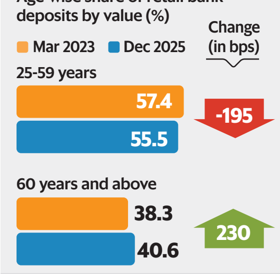
Losing touch

Younger savers are no longer reliant on banks to grow their money.

Age-wise share of retail bank deposits by value (%)



Source: RBI

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

AI boom may trigger chip challenge for auto firms

Ayaan Kartik & Shouvik Das
NEW DELHI

India's automakers could be heading toward another semiconductor supply squeeze—this time triggered by the artificial intelligence (AI) boom. As chipmakers shift manufacturing capacity toward high-bandwidth memory (HBM) for AI data centres, supplies of conventional memory chips used in vehicles are tightening, driving up prices and raising supply risks for the industry.

This could mark the third major supply disruption for the auto industry in recent years, after the rare earth magnet crunch triggered by China's restrictions last year, and the global semiconductor shortage during the covid pandemic years of 2020-22.

At least two industry executives said if supply pressures persist, automakers may start facing shortages by the end of the next financial year (FY27).

"Internal estimates suggest that the supply crunch will get serious towards the last two quarters of the next financial year, which is why there is a rush to prepare now," one of the executives mentioned

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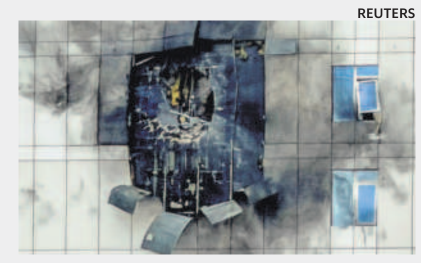
DON'T MISS

REUTERS



Iran continues attacks amid global energy supply worry

Iran attacked commercial ships across the Persian Gulf and targeted Dubai International Airport, escalating a campaign of squeezing the oil-rich region as global energy concerns mounted and American and Israeli airstrikes pounded the Islamic Republic. >P2

Government proposes stricter entry norms for foreign airlines

Foreign airlines seeking to operate flights to India may have to apply through a digital approval system, have a local representative and submit a standardized set of documents, under draft rules aimed at tightening scrutiny of ownership and compliance. >P2

Supreme Court allows first ever case of passive euthanasia

The Supreme Court on Wednesday allowed the withdrawal of artificial life support to a 32-year-old man, in a coma for more than 13 years, saying that the government should consider bringing comprehensive legislation on passive euthanasia. >P9

Sebi curbs, losses fail to deter retail investors from options

The retail investors' enthusiasm for weekly options trading continues unabated despite measures by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) more than a year ago to curb speculative excesses amid mounting losses for individuals. >P4

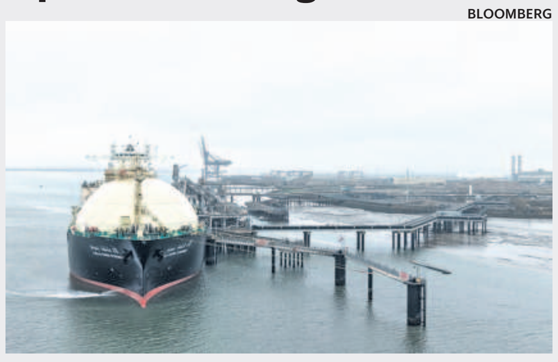
MINT SHORTS

India buys 30 million barrels of Russian oil after US waiver

Indian refiners have bought about 30 million barrels of Russian oil since the US green-lit purchases to help the country cope with a shortfall of supplies from West Asia, people with knowledge of the deals said. India reduced purchases of Russian oil since last year in response to US pressure. Since the US granted the waiver, Indian refiners have snapped up all unsold cargoes of Russian crude in the spot market, said the people. **BLOOMBERG**

Gail buys Oman cargo of liquefied natural gas

BLOOMBERG



New Delhi: Gail has bought an Omani liquefied natural gas (LNG) cargo as India tries to meet its natural gas demand, three traders said. Gail has bought the prompt cargo for delivery next week from a European trader through negotiations at a fixed price of $17–20 per million British thermal units, two of the three persons said. The cargo loaded on the vessel *Orion Hugo*, chartered by Shell, is scheduled to arrive in India around 15 March, Kpler data shows. **REUTERS**

Niti Aayog urges states to adhere to fiscal deficit norms

New Delhi: Government think tank Niti Aayog on Wednesday urged state governments to adhere to fiscal deficit norms under the FRBM Act through disciplined expenditure management, broadening the GST base, and enhancing their own tax capacity. Niti Aayog's 2026 Fiscal Health Index (FHI) for 2023-24 suggests states with widening revenue deficits should prioritize aligning revenue expenditure with sustainable revenue growth. **PTI**

India developing 3 types of small modular reactors: govt

ISTOCKPHOTO

New Delhi: India is developing three different types of small modular reactors (SMRs), including one meant for hydrogen generation, the government informed the Lok Sabha on Wednesday. In a written reply, Union minister Jitendra Singh stated that the three types are the 220 MWe Bharat Small Modular Reactor (BSMR-200), the 55 MWe SMR (SMR-55), and a 5 MWth high-temperature gas-cooled reactor (HTGCR) for hydrogen generation. **PTI**

LPG worries drive sale of induction cooktops, electric kettles

New Delhi: Sales of induction cooktops and electric kettles have surged in the wake of cooking gas supply concerns due to the war in West Asia, according to industry players. Tata Group's Croma said it has observed a threefold jump in demand for induction cooktops over the past few days, while Stovekraft Ltd, the company behind the popular kitchen appliance brand Pigeon, noted that its average weekly online sales have jumped four times. **PTI**

Bharat Taxi service to expand to all big cities in 2-3 years: Minister

New Delhi: The government on Wednesday said the cooperative sector ride-hailing service Bharat Taxi will be expanded to all big cities and talukas in the next 2-3 years. In reply to questions on job creation by cooperative societies in the Rajya Sabha, minister of state for cooperation Krishan Pal said Bharat Taxi was started to empower drivers and increase their income. **PTI**

Iran continues attacks amid global energy supply worry

Iran's military plans to start targeting banks and financial institutions in West Asia

AP
feedback@livemint.com
DUBAI

Iran attacked commercial ships on Wednesday across the Persian Gulf and targeted Dubai International Airport, escalating a campaign of squeezing the oil-rich region as global energy concerns mounted and American and Israeli airstrikes pounded the Islamic Republic.

Two Iranian drones hit near Dubai International Airport, home to the long-haul carrier Emirates and the world's busiest for international travel. Four people were wounded but flights continued, the Dubai Media Office said.

Iran's joint military command announced it would start targeting banks and financial institutions in West Asia. That would put at risk particularly Dubai, in UAE, which is home to many international financial institutions, as well as Saudi Arabia and the island kingdom of Bahrain.

Earlier, a projectile hit a Thai cargo ship off the coast of Oman in the Strait of Hormuz, setting it ablaze. Authorities are searching for three missing crew members from the *Mayuree Naree* after 20 were rescued by the Omani navy, according to Thailand's Marine Department.

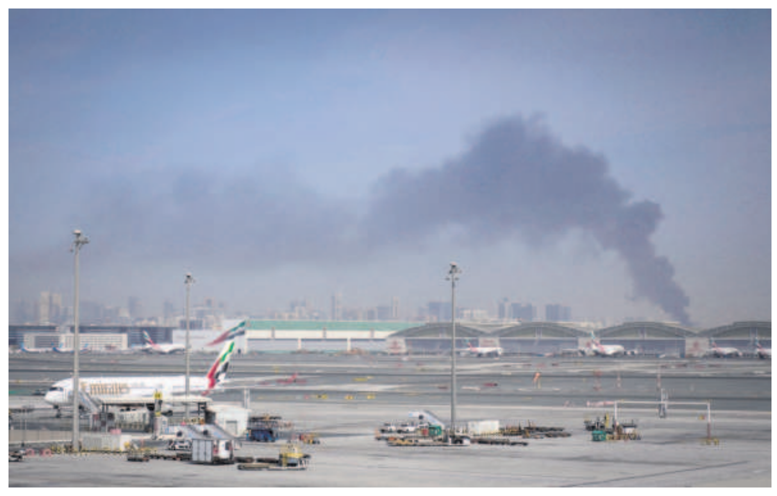
Meanwhile, an assessment from Israeli intelligence said it believed Iran's new supreme leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, was wounded at the start of the war.

An Israeli intelligence official and a reservist with knowledge of the situation spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to discuss the matter with the media. They gave no details on the nature of the injuries.

Separately, Kuwait said its defenses downed eight Iranian drones and Saudi Arabia said it intercepted five heading towards the kingdom's Shaybah oil field. Iran has effectively stopped cargo traffic in the narrow strait through which about a fifth of all oil is shipped. It has also targeted oil fields and refineries in Gulf Arab nations, aiming at generating enough global economic pain to pressure the US and Israel to end their strikes.

Witnesses reported continuous airstrikes hitting Tehran after Israel said it had renewed its attacks. Explosions were also heard in Beirut and in southern Lebanon after Israel said it was hitting targets connected to Iran-backed Hezbollah militants. Lebanon's health ministry said Wednesday that 570 people have been killed in the country since that latest fighting began. Israel warned of Iranian attacks and sirens rang out in Tel Aviv and elsewhere, but there were no immediate reports of casualties.

Oil prices remained well below Monday's peaks but the price of Brent crude, the international standard, was still up some 20% Wednesday from when the war began, and consumers around the world are already feeling the pain at the pump.



Two Iranian drones hit near Dubai International Airport, home to the long-haul carrier Emirates and the world's busiest for international travel. REUTERS

WAR CONTINUES

A projectile hit a Thai cargo ship off the coast of Oman in the Strait of Hormuz, setting it ablaze

AUTHORITIES were searching for three missing crew of the ship while Omani navy rescued 20

KUWAIT said it downed 8 Iranian drones; Saudi said it stopped five headed for an oil field

WITNESSES reported continuous airstrikes on Tehran after Israel renewed its attacks

'Prepare for oil at $200 a barrel'

Iran said the world should be prepared for oil to hit $200 a barrel as its forces attacked merchant ships on Wednesday in the blockaded Gulf.

Oil prices that shot up earlier this week have eased and stock markets have rebounded, with investors betting for now that US President Donald Trump will find a quick way to end the war he began alongside Israel nearly two weeks ago. **REUTERS**

28 Indian ships stuck in Persian Gulf: govt

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NEW DELHI

A total of 28 India-flagged ships with 778 Indian seafarers are stranded in the Persian Gulf region due to the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, the government said on Wednesday.

Of these, 24 vessels are located west of the strait, while the rest are in the east, officials said, adding that their safety and security are being actively monitored by the government.

"A total of 24 Indian-flagged vessels with 677 Indian seafarers are currently located to the west of the Strait of Hormuz, while four vessels with 101 Indian seafarers are to the east of the crucial waterway," Rajesh Kumar Sinha, special secretary in the shipping ministry told reporters.

The most recent conflicts in West Asia have resulted in Indian casualties, too. Two Indians were killed and another reported missing following two recent attacks on oil tankers in the Persian Gulf, said the spokesperson of the external affairs ministry, Randhir Jaiswal. Officials said that a 24-hour control room has been operational in the ministry and the Directorate General of Shipping since 28 February to monitor developments and coordinate assistance.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Government proposes stricter entry norms for foreign airlines

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Foreign airlines seeking to operate flights to India may soon have to apply through a digital approval system, appoint a local representative and submit a standardized set of documents, under draft rules aimed at tightening scrutiny of ownership and regulatory compliance.

The move seeks to streamline approvals while ensuring that only airlines meeting safety and operational standards are allowed to run scheduled services to and from India. The regulator has invited feedback on the draft by 9 April 2026.

For passengers, the change is unlikely to immediately affect fares or flight availability.

The draft framework issued by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), and uploaded on its website, has proposed that foreign carriers register on the civil aviation ministry's e-governance portal and submit applications online to obtain operating authorization before launching flights to India. Such approvals are currently largely handled through correspondence-based submissions to the regulator, with documentation requirements determined on a case-by-case basis. The new system aims to replace that with a uniform portal-based process.

"An airline shall register itself on E-Governance of Civil Aviation portal... by creating unique login ID and password (Login Credentials) and providing .... details and documents," the draft said. Airlines will need to upload a set of documents, including their incorporation certificate, a valid air operator certificate (AOC), articles of association and details of their management structure and registered addresses.

A key addition in the draft is the requirement for foreign airlines to appoint an authorized representative in India who will act as the local point of contact for regulatory communication and compliance.

"Airline (foreign carrier) shall nominate or appoint a local representative to represent it before DGCA for all operational matters, passenger grievances, etc," the draft said, specifying that such a person must be an Indian or a resident of India. This could also be a legal entity incorporated or registered in the country.

Until now, foreign carriers operating flights to India typically maintained local offices, ground-handling arrangements or general sales agents, but the requirement for a formally designated local representative was not explicitly codified as part of the operating authorization framework.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

The move seeks to streamline approvals, while also ensuring safety standards. BLOOMBERG

Bangladesh urges India to up diesel supply amid shortages

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Bangladesh has approached the Indian government to increase petroleum product exports from state-run Oil India Ltd's Numaligarh Refinery through the India-Bangladesh Friendship Pipeline, according to three people familiar with the developments.

While India has yet to accept the request, officials say it may consider raising supplies, critical for Bangladesh's key textile industry. The request comes as Bangladesh faces severe energy strain due to the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz amid the Iran war.

"A request from Bangladesh has been received by India. The pipeline has a maximum capacity of 1 million tonne per annum, the quantum currently procured is much less. So, there is scope of further increase in supplies, if required. If the situation requires, the request may be considered," said one of the three people mentioned above.

An official with Numaligarh Refinery said the company currently supplies around 100,000 tonnes of diesel per annum to Bangladesh, "as per the usual trade. No special supplies have been added," and that no directive to increase supply has been issued yet.

Queries emailed to spokespersons of India's ministries of petroleum and natural gas, external affairs, and the embassy of Bangladesh remained unanswered till press time. Bangladesh's finance minister Amir Khasru Mahmud Chowdhury raised the request over the weekend in a meeting with Indian high commissioner Pranay Verma.

An official with the Bangladesh embassy in Delhi, speaking on condition of anonymity, said, "Bangladesh has been sourcing energy from India for several years now. Some demand have been put forward to increase the diesel supplies in the wake of the global situation. There is no update on a response so far."

This request is additional to the 5,000 tonnes of diesel already sent to Bangladesh Petroleum Corp. (BPC) under an existing agreement signed in December. On Monday, around 5,000 tonnes of diesel were supplied via the Bangladesh India Friendship Pipeline, expected to reach the Parbatipur depot in Dinajpur within about 44 hours.

BPC's general manager for commerce and operations, Muhammad Morshed Hossain Azad, said around 113 tonnes of diesel are pumped each hour, with the consignment likely to be delivered by Wednesday evening.

This request is in addition to the 5,000 tonnes of diesel already sent to BPC. BLOOMBERG

Centre reviews workplace standards to align with new labour codes

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The government has initiated a study to review and revise India's workplace social accountability standard, a move that could shape how companies structure compliance and governance practices as the country prepares to operationalize its new labour codes, said two government officials.

The Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) has commissioned research to examine whether amendments are needed to its existing Social Accountability at the Workplace norms, which set out requirements for organizations to establish policies, procedures and practices related to ethical conduct and workers' welfare, the officials said, speaking on the condition of anonymity. The study will assess the relevance of the existing framework in light of recent policy and regulatory changes aimed at strengthening labour protections, the first of the two officials said.

Mint reviewed the terms of reference for the research and development (R&D) project. These include reforms relating to child labour, forced labour, anti-discrimination provisions, whistleblower protection, data privacy and workplace safety, this person said.

"Updating the workplace social accountability standard is important at a time when India's labour regulations are undergoing major changes," said Sumita Dawra, former labour secretary. "As the four labour codes aim to simplify compliance while strengthening worker protection, revising such standards can help organisations align their internal policies with evolving legal and ethical expectations at the workplace."

Social accountability in the workplace refers to organisations' responsibility to operate in a manner that considers the well-being of employees and other stakeholders. It involves transparency, ethical practices and adherence to labour standards that go beyond basic legal compliance. In response to a *Mint* query, Amit Kumar Singh, deputy director-marketing & consumer affairs, BIS, said the respective sectional committee reviews all published Indian standards every five years.

"The review [of IS 16001:2012] also aims to ensure that the standard remains relevant, contemporary and aligned with current national priorities and global best practices," Singh said. "The review will also take into account the R&D study conducted by BITS Pilani on *Study of Social Accountability at the Workplace* to undertake a detailed study on the subject. It will also consider the upcoming implementation of the four labour codes, as well as regulations and policy developments introduced by the government."

Indian businesses are preparing for the implementation of the country's four labour codes —the Code on Wages, 2019; Industrial Relations Code, 2020; Code on Social Security, 2020; and the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020—which consolidate and modernize nearly 29 labour laws governing wages, industrial relations, social security and workplace safety.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

BIS has commissioned research on whether existing Social Accountability at the Workplace norms need revision. BLOOMBERG

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First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream.

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Printed at HT Media Ltd. Press at Plot No. 6, TTC Industrial Area, Thane - Belapur Road, Navi Mumbai - 400 708.

RNI Registration MAHENG/2018/76720; Mint welcomes readers' responses to all articles and editorials. Please include your full name, address and telephone number. Send in your views to the editor at letters@livemint.com.

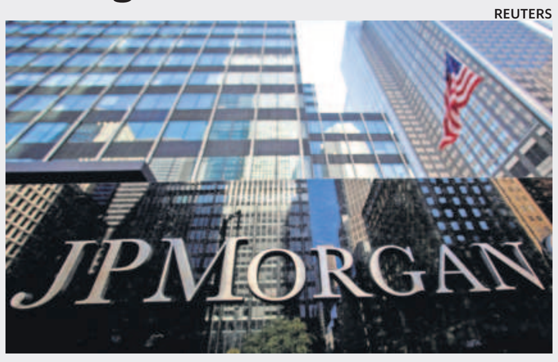
MINT SHORTS

Skye Air Mobility raises $9 mn in Series B funding round

New York: Drone logistics solution provider Skye Air Mobility on Wednesday announced raising a total of $9 million in a Series B funding round to fuel hyperlocal drone delivery expansion. The round structured in two parts—Series B1 of $4 million and Series B2 of $5 million—was led by IAN Group's second venture fund IAN Alpha Fund, and saw participation from AVNM Ventures, Faad Capital, Bajaj Capital, and other prominent investors, the company said. **PTI**

JPMorgan limits private credit lending after loan markdowns

REUTERS



JPMorgan Chase & Co. is restricting some lending to private credit funds after marking down the value of certain loans in their portfolios, according to a person familiar with the matter, in the latest sign of stress in the $1.8 trillion industry. The devalued loans are to software companies, the person added, a sector that's been in the spotlight in recent weeks due to investor concern over the potential impact of artificial intelligence. The decision was reported earlier by the *Financial Times*. **BLOOMBERG**

Amazon is raising a record €14.5 billion from euro bond sale

Amazon.com Inc. is raising €14.5 billion ($16.8 billion) in its euro bond market debut, the biggest ever corporate bond sold in the currency, as Big Tech firms pour money into AI infrastructure. The tech giant boosted the deal from the €10 billion size expected by the market on Tuesday and is offering maturities ranging from two to 38 years, according to people familiar with the matter, who asked not to be identified. **BLOOMBERG**

Nvidia to invest $2 billion in Nebius to build AI data centres

Nvidia Corp. will invest $2 billion in Nebius Group NV as part of a strategic partnership to develop and build AI data centres, as it continues to pour money into companies that buy its chips. The deal will help Nebius deploy more than 5 gigawatts of Nvidia systems by the end of 2030, the firm stated Wednesday. **BLOOMBERG**

KKR eyes multiple platforms for renewable assets in India

Private equity giant is vying for larger assets, like Sprng Energy, through its Asia fund

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KKR plans to own multiple independent platforms for renewable energy assets in India, a key market for the global private equity giant, where it is betting on infrastructure and financial services to consumer technology.

KKR is vying for larger assets, such as Sprng Energy and Gentari, directly through its Asia fund, rather than via its renewable energy platform, Serentica. "The idea is to have multiple energy platforms in the country," said a person with knowledge of the firm's strategy.

"The assets are large, and Serentica does not have the debt gearing or equity to finance those deals. The firm is planning to bid independently. Renewables is a sector they are globally betting big on," said a second person aware of the matter–both spoke on the condition of anonymity.

KKR joins Blackstone, Brookfield, Actis, and Macquarie in ramping up their India bets and have been looking at building platforms by acquiring assets. That contrasts with the playbook of many global energy majors, which have either exited the country or are looking to sell, given high valuations.

A KKR spokesperson declined to comment in an emailed response.

The PE giant has made substantial investments in Serentica, including a $400 million commitment in 2022 and an additional $250 million in 2023. Last year, KKR helped Serentica acquire the Indian solar business of Norwegian state-owned company Statkraft for an enterprise value estimated between $220-250 million (about ₹1,942-2,207 crore).

KKR, Blackstone, Brookfield, Actis, and Macquarie have been looking at building platforms by acquiring assets. BLOOMBERG

In a media roundtable held in November last year, Scott Nuttall, KKR's global chief executive, said it sees India as one of its key markets. "We are going to deploy more in healthcare, but we're also going to expand across consumer, technology, and financial services as well as in infrastructure, including renewables, roads, transmission grids, and data centres," Nuttall had said.

The firm has invested $9 billion across private equity (PE), debt and infrastructure in the last five years locally.

Earlier this year, global oil major Shell Plc put its India renewable energy business Sprng Energy on the block. The deal, valuing the company at $1.7-$1.8 billion, has seen a lot of interest from players such as National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF), Sembcorp, Blackstone, Macquarie, Actis, among others. Similarly, Gentari India, the Malaysia energy group's local arm, is looking to sell a controlling stake in the company and has seen interest from the large buyers mentioned above, *Mint* reported.

Despite hitting record installation milestones, India's green energy sector continues to face challenges: nearly 44 gigawatts of awarded projects remain stranded without power purchase agreements, cash-strapped discoms are shunning solar due to stagnant demand, and exchange prices have crashed to near-zero levels during peak generation hours.

Many companies in the renewable and energy space owned by global PE firms or strategic investors such as Vibrant Energy, Statkraft Group and Zelestra have either sold or are looking to sell their India portfolio.

India is targeting net-zero emissions by 2070, aiming for 500 GW of renewable energy by 2030 and a 45% reduction in greenhouse emissions intensity.

INVESTING BIG

KKR has made big investments in Serentica, including a $400 million commitment in 2022

LAST year, KKR helped Serentica acquire the Indian solar business of Norway's Statkraft

THE firm has invested $9 billion across PE, debt and infrastructure in the past 5 years locally

MANY RE firms owned by global PE firms have either sold or plan to sell their India portfolio

Flipkart has held informal talks with bankers and investors. MINT

Flipkart is planning to invite banks to pitch for IPO in April

Bloomberg
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Online retailer Flipkart Internet Pvt. Ltd is set to start the formal process for banks to pitch for work on its potential initial public offering (IPO) as soon as next month, according to people familiar with the matter.

The Walmart Inc.-backed e-commerce company has already held informal talks with investors and bankers to gauge appetite for a listing in Mumbai, the people said. An IPO could take place later this year or early 2027, they said, asking not to be identified because the information isn't public.

Deliberations are at an early stage and details such as timing may change, the people said. A Flipkart representative didn't respond to a request for comment.

If the IPO goes ahead, it is likely to include a secondary share sale by existing investors such as Walmart, the people said. Flipkart will use the proceeds to expand the business, they added.

Founded in 2007, Flipkart has become one of India's biggest e-commerce platforms, with a registered customer base of more than 500 million, according to its website. Walmart bought a 77% stake for $16 billion in 2018 and later increased that holding with further acquisitions. A 2023 purchase of Tiger Global Management's remaining stake valued Flipkart at $35 billion at the time.

Moneycontrol reported last week that Flipkart was in preliminary discussions with investment banks about the listing.

Flipkart said Monday it had received government approval to shift its domicile from Singapore to India, a key step towards a listing in the country, where 2025 was a boom for share sales. Other listed companies in Indian e-commerce include Lenskart Solutions Ltd., Swiggy Ltd, and Zomato. Sentiment has cooled in 2026 after some disappointing debuts and a nearly 10% decline in the Sensex.

Qualcomm arm eyes India startups to build low-cost AI

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Chipmaker Qualcomm's venture capital arm is looking to back local startups building artificial intelligence (AI) technologies affordable enough to scale globally through its $150 million India-focused fund, according to a top executive at the firm.

With its second India-focused fund, Qualcomm Ventures is looking for founders who are reducing the cost of deploying AI applications, an area where it say Indian startups have a natural advantage.

"Looking at the Indian startup ecosystem, companies here are in the unique position to make AI affordable globally," Rama Bethmangalkar, managing director at Qualcomm Ventures India, told *Mint*. "With the population and purchasing power that the country has, companies can't afford to make solutions which are not designed with the Indian price point in mind."

Rama Bethmangalkar, managing director at Qualcomm Ventures India.

Qualcomm's CEO Cristiano Amon had announced the AI-focused $150 million fund at the India AI Impact Summit held in Delhi last month. With the new fund, the firm plans to invest across deeptech, AI applications spanning both B2B and B2C markets, and enterprise technology.

Qualcomm Ventures, at least in India, is particularly focused on companies built around artificial intelligence from the outset. "Founders who are pushing the envelope on difficult problem statements and are looking to solve them from an Indian perspective are the kind of people that excite us," Bethmangalkar said.

The firm is bullish on is physical AI, including robotics systems that can automate industrial workflows, he said. It's an area where companies and investors are increasingly looking to reduce labour while ensuring minimal downtime.

Qualcomm's CEO had announced the AI-focused $150 mn fund at the India AI Impact Summit in Delhi last month

Premji Invest led a $450 million round in AI robotics company Rhoda AI with participation from Khosla Ventures, Temasek Holdings and Silicon Valley billionaire John Doerr, valuing the firm at $1.7 billion.

Homegrown robotics company CynLr last month announced a new tech suite which lets robots learn on the fly, much like a human child, instead of requiring reinforcement learning. Hyundai, through its subsidiary Boston Dynamics, has pledged to build and deploy 30,000 units annually by 2028 humanoid robots to place in its manufacturing plants in the US.

"Interest in deep tech and AI in India is steadily increasing, but it will not follow the same rapid funding cycles seen in other startup sectors," said Amit Nawka, partner, deals and startups leader at PwC India. "The space involves longer development cycles and the added uncertainty of fast-evolving technologies. As a result, investors are often placing a wider set of bets across the ecosystem, recognising that it will take time to see which technologies and business models ultimately prevail."

For an extended version of the story, visit livemint.com

RBI clears Cred as a payment aggregator

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NEW DELHI

Fintech platform Cred on Wednesday said it has received the final authorization from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to operate as a payment aggregator.

With this, Cred and its subsidiaries now hold two RBI authorisations, including the Prepaid Payment Instrument (PPI) licence.

"The RBI has formally authorized Cred (Dreamplug Paytech Solutions Pvt. Ltd) to operate a payment system directly under the regulator's supervision. The licence enables Cred to onboard merchants, collect payments on their behalf across instruments, and handle settlement and refunds," the company said in a statement. The Bengaluru-based firm reported a reduction in operating losses to ₹298 crore in FY25, from ₹609 crore in FY24, on the back of product portfolio expansion.

It saw its consolidated operating revenue grow by 16% to ₹2,735 crore in FY25.

"Stakeholder trust has been central to how we've built Cred from the get-go; we've operated with a high bar for performance, reliability, transparency, and governance from day zero.

"The authorization to operate as a payment aggregator reflects the trust we've consistently built across the ecosystem and sets the foundation for the next chapter of enabling financial progress for India's most creditworthy," Cred founder Kunal Shah said.

Surging domestic capital spawns Indian angel funds

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India's angel networks are increasingly creating their own funds, tapping into the surge of domestic capital to institutionalise early-stage investing in the country's startup ecosystem.

To streamline their investment focus, these networks are shifting from deal-by-deal syndication to closed-ended funds, capitalizing on the surge in domestic capital available.

"Failure rates for individual angels can be very high, and coming together to structure their investing is a way of addressing that failure rate," said Ranjeet Shetye, a deeptech angel investor and a mentor at YourNest Venture Capital.

Veteran networks like Indian Angel Network (now IAN Group), Hyderabad Angels, and Rajasthan Angels have launched their own funds. These networks have successfully identified enough winners, encouraging investors to supply capital for early-stage bets rather than engaging directly in deal-making.

Hyderabad Angels Fund (HAF) launched their maiden fund last year, but it is relatively small at ₹150 crore. The firm is fundraising and has already raised ₹85 crore. Its four investments include two in aerospace, one in gaming and another in enterprise.

"Generally, while networks have their own benefits, there are limitations in terms of the deals they can attract, the process of funding a round and the predictability of whether a fund will go through or not," said Kalyan Sivalenka, managing partner at HAF. "For Hyderabad, it was also time to institutionalise the capital here because there's a lot of capital available here from founders who have had great exits."

Mahavir Sharma of Rajasthan Angel Network leveraged the network's 30 operators to launch his own ₹150 crore venture fund.

To streamline their investment focus, these networks are shifting from deal-by-deal syndication to closed-ended funds. ISTOCKPHOTO

IAN Group was, in fact, the earliest angel network in the country to set up its own fund. The maiden investment vehicle was launched in 2019 and was sized at ₹375 crore with institutional and high net worth individuals pooling money, including Sidbi's Fund of Funds, India Infoline, Infosys co-founder Kris Gopalakrishnan, and Kanwal Rekhi. The investment network's second fund is even larger, sitting at $100 million and was launched late last year.

For many angel investors, the shift is being led by Sebi's decision to revise the accredited investor framework. Regulations require angel funds to have at least five accredited investors before their first close. The designation requires investors to have a certain net worth and have a chartered accountant sign off on their financials.

Sharma, chairman and co-founder of the Rajasthan Angel Network, said while angel investors have lost capital due to a lack of robust rights compared to venture funds, current regulations have made the investment process overly complicated. "I wouldn't have been able to be an angel investor if these regulations had existed back in 2011-12."

For angel investors, the shift is led by Sebi's move to revise accredited investor framework

Unlike individual angels, formal funds professionalize due diligence and reporting while providing a diversified portfolio that hedges against single-startup failures and secures the board-level influence usually reserved for larger VC firms.

India's large venture fund houses, such as Peak XV, Kalaari Capital, Blume Ventures, and Nexus Venture Partners, have raised funds from a mix of global and domestic institutional investors. But as angels look to formalise, there's also a need for general partners (GPs) with a track record of picking the right bets.

"We are seeing more Indian funds come up, led by GPs who have built their credibility at global firms and are now venturing out to set up their own funds in India," said Sanjiv Bhatia, president and head of multinational corporations, new economy and financial sponsors at Axis Bank. He said the number of angel investors has grown significantly, driven by a rise in India's HNI population.

Anarock projects that India's HNI population will double to 1.65 million by 2027, while CareEdge Ratings attributes this growth to economic liberalisation, startup wealth creation, and intergenerational wealth transfers.

Index	Close	Percent change	Previous close	Open	High	Low
BSE Sensex	76,863.71	-1.72	78,205.98	78,238.91	78,324.37	76,759.26
Nifty 50	23,866.85	-1.63	24,261.60	24,231.85	24,299.00	23,834.30
Nifty 500	22,042.30	-1.35	22,342.95	22,351.85	22,440.90	22,009.30
Nifty Next 50	66,498.65	-1.08	67,227.95	67,375.90	67,765.40	66,363.70
Nifty 100	24,574.55	-1.54	24,957.80	24,941.60	25,020.50	24,538.80
BSE 150 MidCap	15,279.08	-1.13	15,453.74	15,492.04	15,571.31	15,253.81
BSE 250 SmallCap	6,056.03	-0.32	6,075.67	6,092.52	6,143.80	6,046.75

Tyre firms may face cost shock

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Indian tyre companies are staring at a potential dual cost pinch scenario that can dent their growth prospects. The cost of natural rubber has been rising over the last two months amid a global supply crunch. Extreme weather conditions in major Southeast Asian nations have disrupted production.

From ₹18,500 per 100 kg in January, natural rubber price has risen to ₹21,600 in March so far.

Soaring crude oil prices would add to this pain. Since the Iran-US-Israel conflict broke out, Brent crude has increased by 17% to around $87 a barrel on fears of a supply shock.

Natural rubber accounts for 30% of the raw material mix for tyre makers, 70% is dominated by crude-linked derivatives synthetic rubber (20%), carbon black (25%), and fabric (10%), according to Icra Ltd.

The rupee's depreciation to 91.88 to the dollar would inflate import cost of raw materials. "Tyres sector is the largest consumer of natural rubber in India, accounting for 65–70% of overall consumption; about 55-60% of natural rubber demand is met from local production, and the balance through imports," said Srikumar Krishnamurthy, senior vice president and co-group head, corporate ratings, Icra.

The downside risks to the sector's profitability have increased and may rise further if the ongoing conflict prolongs. The impact of rising costs on margins comes with a lag, depending on inventory levels. Sure, price hikes can be taken to protect margins, but prevailing competitive intensity would limit that ability.

Hikes may come at the expense of market share. If Brent stays around $80 a barrel and domestic natural rubber stays around ₹220 per kg for three-six months, CLSA estimates a 400 basis points gross-margin hit for Indian tyre makers, even after assuming a staggered 4% price hike in the replacement market and full pass-through by original equipment makers (OEMs).

Tyre makers' volume recovered sequentially in the December quarter (Q3FY26) led by robust OEM and replacement demand, supported by rationalization of goods and services tax rate, festive season and improving rural traction. Better product mix, relatively benign raw material costs and operating leverage aided margin expansion.

But the ride seems turbulent in Q4. During the Q3 earnings call, Ceat cautioned of a sequential margin impact of 100–150 basis points in Q4 due to currency movements and higher international rubber prices.

JK Tyre & Industries was confident of absorbing a 1–2% uptick in raw material cost via premiumization and operating leverage.

Despite increased input costs, JK targets Ebitda margin sustaining at 13–15% in Q4 and FY27. But now this optimism could be put to the test.

The tyre industry has limited raw material reliance on West Asia, with imports largely sourced from Southeast Asia.

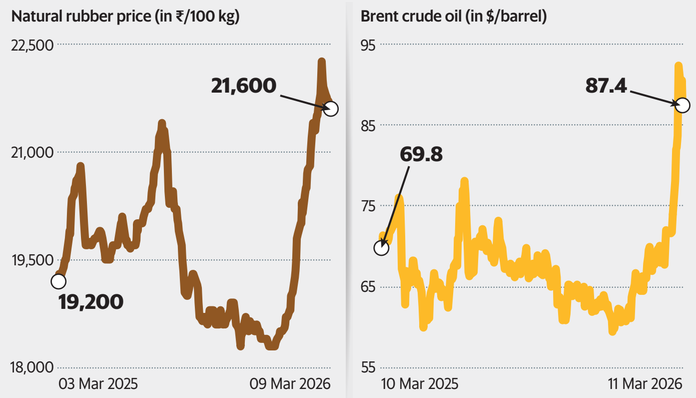
"The more immediate impact of the current West Asia disruption is likely to be logistics-related, with higher freight and insurance costs affecting both imports and exports," said Poonam Upadhyay, director, Crisil Ratings.

"This could start reflecting in March export shipments, particularly as exports account for about 25% of the tyre industry's total volumes."

So far in 2026, shares of MRF, JK Tyre and Apollo Tyres have declined over 10% each as worries of de-rating linger despite valuations looking reasonable.

Double trouble

Tyre companies' profit margins face risk due to rising prices of crucial inputs natural rubber and crude oil.



Source: Bloomberg, ICICI Securities
Source: Bloomberg
mint
MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

BUMPY ROAD

THE rupee's depreciation to 91.88 to the dollar would inflate import cost of raw materials

THE impact of rising costs on margins comes with a lag, depending on inventory levels

Dixon's HKC tie-up nod lifts outlook, but valuations high

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Dixon Technologies (India) Ltd has received long-awaited government approval for its joint venture (JV) with Hong Kong–based HKC Corp., a partnership first announced in June 2024. The JV will manufacture LCD and TFT-LCD display modules for smartphones, televisions, laptops, and automotive displays, removing a regulatory hurdle that had delayed the project.

Beyond providing incremental growth, the venture marks an important step in Dixon's effort to move up the electronics manufacturing value chain. The company is an electronics manufacturing services (EMS) assembler, which runs on thin margins due to low value added. Dixon's Ebitda margin for the nine months ended December (9MFY26) was just 4%.

Now, Dixon will be able to manufacture display modules in India. These modules account for 10-12% of the bill of materials in smartphones.

"This foray into display modules deepens Dixon's presence in the component ecosystem, with the level of backward integration in smartphones expected to rise by about 10-12% from 16-17% now," said Emkay Global Financial Services.

Dixon is expected to produce around 24 million smartphone displays and 2 million laptop displays annually in the first phase. It plans to invest ₹1,100–1,200 crore in the project. Trial production is expected to begin in June–July, with commercial production likely from September. The financial impact is expected to become more visible from FY28 onwards as it ramps up smartphone display capacity to 55 million units.

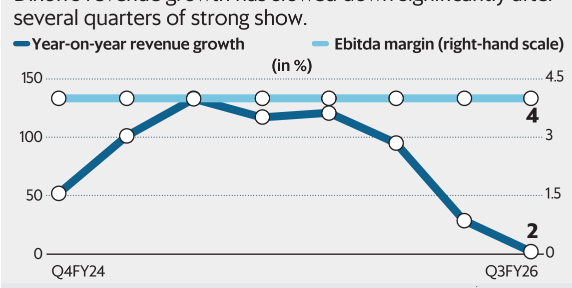
Nomura estimates the display business alone could add about 50 basis points to Dixon's margins by FY28. The brokerage expects revenue to grow to ₹91,021 crore by FY28 from ₹38,860 crore in FY25.

Dixon's shares, however, have fallen 43% from 52-week high of ₹18,471 reached on 25 September. Mobile volume prospects had been clouded by delays in approvals for the Vivo and HKC joint ventures, along with rising memory module prices, hurting demand for lower-end smartphones. Dixon's Q3FY26 revenue grew 2% on-year against 53% growth in H1FY26.

The stock trades at around 37x its FY28 estimated earnings, reflecting expectations of strong growth and successful backward integration. Much of the optimism appears priced in, leaving limited room for execution missteps.

Hitting a pause

Dixon's revenue growth has slowed down significantly after several quarters of strong show.



Ebitda: Earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation, and amortization
Source: Company
mint
MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Sebi mulls faster 'lodge and launch' route for AIFs

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India's capital markets regulator is exploring faster approvals for alternative investment funds (AIFs) to boost sentiment and participation in the fast-growing segment.

It is evaluating a "lodge and launch" framework that could significantly shorten the time taken for new AIF schemes to come to market, said Tuhin Kanta Pandey, chairperson of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) at the IVCA Conclave on Wednesday.

Under the proposed model, Sebi may rely on due diligence certificates issued by merchant bankers for certain AIF schemes. For schemes intended exclusively for accredited investors, the responsibility for disclosure diligence would rest with the AIF manager.

"This framework can improve ease of doing business, accelerate fund launches, and support faster mobilization of private capital," the Sebi chief said. "As always, we will consult with the industry on this proposal."

India's AIF industry, which pools funds from sophisticated investors to invest in startups and private equity to infrastructure, has expanded rapidly in recent years. The country now has over 1,700 registered AIFs. As of December, total commitments to these funds stood at about ₹15.74 trillion, while investments had reached around ₹6.45 trillion. The industry has grown at a compound annual growth rate of nearly 30% over the past five years, according to Sebi.

Sebi chairperson Tuhin Kanta Pandey. MINT

Sebi is looking to ease the process and reduce the cost of accreditation. Accredited investors are individuals or entities certified to have a high net worth, income, or financial sophistication, allowing them to invest in complex products such as AIFs with fewer regulatory protections.

"We are exploring ways to leverage digital public infrastructure to further ease and streamline the process of accreditation," Pandey said, adding that cutting costs will help make the process accessible to eligible investors.

The number of accredited investors rose to 2,181 as of February 20 from 649 in May 2025. Such investors account for about 30% of total AIF investments.

The Sebi chief flagged several challenges and risks of investing in AIFs that investors should be cautious about. One of the key concerns is mis-selling. AIFs have complex structures, illiquid assets and long holding periods. Pandey said distributors and managers must ensure that disclosures are clear and that risk profiling becomes a genuine exercise rather than a formality.

For an extended version of the story, visit livemint.com

The market regulator is looking to ease the process and reduce the cost of accreditation

Sebi curbs, losses fail to deter retail investors from options

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The retail investors' enthusiasm for weekly options trading continues unabated despite measures by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) more than a year ago to curb speculative excesses amid mounting losses for individuals.

Analysts said the growth in options turnover is likely to outpace that of the cash market, amid heightened volatility across financial markets caused by the US-Iran conflict.

In an interaction with *PTI* last week, Sebi chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said that while the regulator has no concerns about the futures segment of the derivatives market, it remains watchful of speculative trading in short-dated options.

Combined average daily premium turnover (ADT) of index options such as Nifty and Sensex rose 5% even as combined cash market ADT dipped by almost 8% in the current fiscal through 9 March (FY26), from a year earlier.

In absolute terms, index options' ADT rose to ₹67,143 crore from ₹63,828 crore in the period under review, while cash market ADT slipped to ₹1.12 trillion in the current fiscal (1 Apr 2025 -9 Mar 2026) from ₹1.22 trillion in FY25 (1 April 2024-7 Mar 2025).

The rise in combined options turnover comes despite regulatory curbs such as limiting index options expiry to one per exchange from multiple earlier, and tripling contract sizes to ₹15-20 lakh from ₹5 -10 lakh, among other measures, since November 2024.

The National Stock Exchange (NSE) offers weekly Nifty options every Tuesday while the BSE offers Sensex options every Thursday.

"The increase in combined index options turnover in the current fiscal through 9 March is because of a shift in share from discontinued weekly options contracts, like Bank Nifty, Midcap Nifty and Finnifty, on NSE to the Sensex options," said Amit Chandra, vice-president (research) at HDFC Securities.

The regulatory curbs came after Sebi in a September 2024 study found that retail investors suffered a combined net loss of ₹1.81 trillion trading largely options during FY22-24.

Despite the curbs, however, market experts expect the trend to continue.

"Most retail investors lack the expertise to trade options, and with heightened volatility induced first by global tariff uncertainty and now the war in West Asia, it's easier for such novices to take a view over 5 days rather than for a longer horizon," said Rajesh Palviya, senior vice-president (derivatives and technical research), Axis Securities. "This will ensure that participation in weekly options keeps growing despite the regulatory measures to curb excesses," he said.

For an extended version of the story, visit livemint.com

Combined index options ADT rose 5%, while cash market ADT fell 8% in FY26 through 9 March from a year earlier. PTI

Analysts said options turnover may outpace that of cash market amid volatility driven by the US-Iran conflict

Adani unit secures $500 mn funding

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Adani Transmission Step-One Limited (ATSOL), a wholly-owned subsidiary of listed Adani Energy Solutions Ltd, has raised $500 million through dollar-denominated bonds privately placed with Apollo Global Management, according to two people in the know. A spokesperson for Apollo Global subsequently confirmed the transaction in an email to *Mint*.

The capital will be used to refinance $500 million of ATSOL bonds that are maturing in early August. ATSOL had issued these bonds in 2016 with a 4% coupon, according to data from Bloomberg.

In January, ATSOL's senior secured bond ratings of Baa3 was affirmed by Moody's and its outlook was changed to stable from negative. This rating is in line with the American credit evaluator's India's sovereign rating and is the lowest tier in the investment grade.

The Adani Group did not respond immediately to *Mint's* request for comment.

AESL's net debt stood at ₹36,113 crore as of September 2025. It did not disclose its net debt as of 31 December in its latest earnings presentation.

For an extended version of the story, visit livemint.com

NSE shares: Opaque grey market in focus

Abhinaba Saha &
Apoorva Ajith
MUMBAI

India's lightly regulated market for pre-IPO shares is back in focus after the Enforcement Directorate (ED) launched a probe into the alleged sale of unlisted National Stock Exchange shares, a case that is renewing calls for tighter oversight of the fast-growing segment.

Last week, ED conducted searches at eight locations in Mumbai and Chennai as part of a money laundering investigation linked to the sale of shares of NSE, which is set to hit the public markets soon. The action targeted entities, including Atum Capital Pvt. Ltd, Optimus Financial Solutions Pvt. Ltd, Babli Investment Pvt. Ltd and Supremus Angel, along with their directors.

The agency alleged these entities duped investors by promising unlisted NSE shares they did not possess. The companies then routed investor money through multiple bank accounts and diverted it into movable and immovable assets.

The development underscores the opaque and risky nature of the unlisted share market. The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) considers bringing the segment under its oversight.

Sebi chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said last month the regulator plans to introduce oversight for "to-be-listed" companies through exchange mechanisms, with operational guidelines and consultation papers expected soon. Sebi is also in talks with the central government, since the unlisted market falls under the ministry of corporate affairs.

Last week, ED searched eight locations in Mumbai and Chennai in a money-laundering probe linked to the sale of shares of NSE. AFP

Atum Capital denied any role in the alleged fraud, saying it was itself a victim. "Our role in the transaction was as a buyer...based on a seller's commitment to deliver them. The shares were to be supplied by a third-party entity that ultimately failed to honour its commitment," Satish Kumar, director of Atum Capital said in an email response to *Mint's* query. "A formal complaint has already been filed, and an FIR has been registered with the Economic Offences Wing against the concerned seller."

Kumar is one of the directors named in the probe for allegedly being part of a cartel that promised investors allocations in unlisted NSE shares. He said Atum Capital is cooperating with all investigative authorities on this matter.

Queries emailed to NSE, Optimus Financial Solutions, Babli Investment and Supremus Angel did not elicit a response till press time.

"One of the biggest concerns for investors today is the gap between unlisted market prices and IPO (initial public offering) valuations, which in many cases has widened to 35-40%," Feroze Azeez, joint chief executive officer at Anand Rathi Wealth Ltd said.

Thin liquidity and limited disclosures lead to opaque price discoveries, creating discrepancies between listed and unlisted prices. Last year HDB Financial Services traded above ₹1,200 in the unlisted market, but its IPO price band was set at ₹820-880, leaving unlisted shareholders with steep losses.

"All of these risks are known to investors, still they purchase unlisted shares and may end up burning their hands," said Sudhir Bassi, executive director at law firm Khaitan & Co. Investors buy unlisted shares hoping companies will list at higher valuations and deliver outsized gains, he said.

This often leaves investors vulnerable to illicit intermediaries who exploit their hype and fear of missing out. As a result, intermediary credibility has become a critical concern.

Still, retail investor interest in the unlisted space remains strong. NSE's unlisted shares alone have nearly 184,000 public shareholders, 93% of whom are retail investors willing to absorb sharp price swings. For instance, the shares corrected nearly 20% from their ₹2,400 peak in July 2025 before rebounding about 5% to around ₹2,050 after Sebi's chief commented on the exchange's potential IPO, *Mint* reported earlier.

Bassi said investor awareness programs akin to the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) public awareness campaigns against banking fraud could help, as investments in the unlisted space are often driven more by sentiment than fundamentals.

Akshaya Bhansali, managing partner at Mindspright Legal suggests a small exchange-like platform for 'to-be-listed' companies, as this could help create a formal structure and reduce the scope for exploitation.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

ED alleged that entities duped investors by promising unlisted NSE shares they did not possess

Siemens sees revival of pvt capex amid rising demand

Growth is supported by a strong order book in smart infrastructure and mobility businesses

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When Sunil Mathur was given a five-year extension two years ago, Siemens in India was already a compelling story. Today, with three years still left on his clock, the narrative has shifted from promise to proof.

The numbers speak plainly: revenue doubled at Siemens Ltd, as the Indian unit of the German conglomerate is named, margins tripled, the share price is up 380% over five years, and India is now ranked the fourth-largest country in Siemens AG's €78.9 billion (Rs 8.44 trillion) universe and, like several other MNCs, is its fastest-growing market.

And now, after years of waiting, the one missing ingredient in India may finally be arriving for Siemens. The government's reductions in income tax and good and services tax (GST) rates are beginning to stir private consumption, and Mathur believes by April the first real signs of a revival in private sector capital expenditure must be visible.

The investment community took notice. In a 15 December note, "Ready to Roll," ICICI Securities upgraded Siemens shares to a 'buy' with a revised target price of ₹3,700 each, arguing that earnings are likely to grow by over 15% within two years. Analyst Mohit Kumar, who had earlier put the stock on hold, concluded that a strong order book in the company's smart infrastructure and mobility businesses, an uptick in margins led by the locomotive ramp-up, and the exit from the low-margin low-voltage motors business together create a case for re-rating the stock.

At the Siemens Transform event in Mumbai, Peter Koerte, Siemens AG's chief product officer and Mathur, managing director and CEO, Siemens Ltd, in an exclusive conversation with *Mint*, laid out a vision to capture the shifts reshaping the industry globally.

Mathur has long argued that India's growth story is structural, not cyclical. At an analyst meet after Siemens Ltd's FY2025 results, he pointed to the macro economy: "6.5% growth, from my perspective, is more or less a given. The question is, can we get to 7-7.5%?"

He pointed to the government's twin interventions in reducing income tax and GST rates as the catalysts that could unlock the private consumption cycle that has been stubbornly muted. "The consumption story always takes 5 to 6 months to kick in," he noted, suggesting that by April, the first real signals of a private sector capex revival should emerge. The government had changed GST rates late-September with an eye on consumption.

This matters enormously for Siemens because digital industries, which comprises its automation and industrial software business, is almost entirely private-sector facing. With that segment growing at just 1.5x over five years amid muted private capex, the upside from a genuine revival is substantial. "The expectation is this will grow from around 5% to 8%, possibly more," Mathur told analysts.

Perhaps the most compelling thread running through both conversations is the idea that India can leapfrog the conventional industrial development curve. Mathur drew an analogy to telephony when India skipped fixed-line phones and went straight to mobiles. The question is whether it can do the same with industrial automation, bypassing the slow, sequential ladder of electrify-automate-digitize and reach AI-enabled manufacturing in one bound.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Sunil Mathur, managing director and chief executive officer, Siemens India MINT

AUTOMATION PUSH

MATHUR expects private sector capex to revive by April, aided by govt's tax and GST rate cuts

PROFITABILITY rose with locomotive ramp-up and exit from low-margin motors business

THE company's digital industries segment could gain from a revival in private capex

SIEMENS says India could shift to AI-led manufacturing and advanced industrial automation

Private credit gains ahead of IPOs as founders raise stakes

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Private credit is increasingly being used ahead of public listings to help founders and promoters consolidate stakes or bolster capital as investors seek partial or full exits amid equity market uncertainty.

Over the past 12-14 months, founders or promoters of firms including Symbiotec Pharma, Vivriti Group, Zepto, InMobi, Lenskart, Leap India and Zetwerk have engaged in such deals ahead of their initial public offerings (IPOs), people in the know told *Mint*.

"Credit is increasingly being used as a flexible pool of capital to capture these opportunities and, in some cases, to provide exits to investors, especially when public/IPO markets are facing headwind," said Aakash Desai, chief investment officer and head of private credit at 360 ONE Asset, which closed its fifth private credit fund at $400 million earlier this week.

"We see this trend coming back in a big way and continuing as we deploy capital to finance such transactions."

India's private credit market has grown rapidly, as several domestic and global investment firms offer faster and more flexible capital than traditional lenders can provide to companies. Private credit deployed in India hit a record $12.4 billion in 2025, up about 35% in 2024, according to estimates from consulting firm EY. The growth was led by demand for refinancing and capital expenditures in real estate, healthcare, and infrastructure.

"A lot of businesses we are seeing today are undergoing tremendous growth and are seeing large order books. Some of them have a great earnings cycle," Desai said. "These factors have encouraged promoters to acquire more stake as they expect an uptick in value over the next 3 to 5 years."

Private credit deployment hit an all-time high of $12.4 bn in 2025, growing about 35% from the previous year

For instance, Sunu Mathew, co-promoter of KKR-owned Leap India, took ₹200 crore debt from Motilal Oswal Alternate's private credit fund to consolidate his stake to 26% from the previously held 22%.

The firm recently secured the regulator's approval to proceed with its initial public offering (IPO). Symbiotec Pharmalab's Anil Satwani is engaged in similar discussions with banks to up his shareholding.

Mathew and Satwani did not respond to *Mint's* queries till press time.

Similarly, Vivriti Group, which consolidated its lending and private credit businesses under a new unified structure, received an infusion of ₹200 crore from its promoter, Vineet Sukumar, last month. This increased his stake in the combined entity from 7% to 11.5%. He outlined plans to further increase his stake as the company approaches a public listing over the next three years, *Mint* reported in February.

"There are increasingly more conversations where founders' stakes are reset upwards before an IPO event. This is often a recognition by the private market investors that there is a milestone liquidity event ahead, and founders are unlikely to be able to get equity after listing," said Rajat Ranjan, Kotak Mahindra Capital's managing director of the digital and robotics team. The investment firm also outlined plans to raise a $2 billion private credit fund in October.

"Also, in several instances, any ESOP exercise is also a tax event, and founders need funds," Ranjan said. "More ESOP also conveys greater promoter/founder conviction in the company's journey post the listing and for value-creation purposes."

In general, promoters have been looking to raise capital to shore up ownership. Last year, Mint reported that the founders of InMobi and Zetwerk were separately raising debt in their personal capacity to increase their stakes in their respective companies.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Companies including Zepto, InMobi, Lenskart, Vivriti, Leap India and Zetwerk have tapped private credit ahead of IPOs. REUTERS

Lord's Mark Industries signs pact for AI-based radiation-free breast screening wearable device

Lord's Mark Industries Limited (LMIL) has entered into a technology transfer agreement with the Centre for Materials for Electronic Technology (CMET) to manufacture an AI-powered, radiation-free breast screening wearable device for the early detection of breast cancer.

As per WCRF, India ranks third in new breast cancer incidents globally, accounting for over 26% of all female cancers in the country.

According to *Market Research Future Reports (MRFR)*, the global breast cancer market was valued at $4,882.14 million in 2024 and is projected to reach $12,880.85 million by 2035 at a CAGR of 9.22%. *Grand View Research* highlights diagnostics as the dominant segment driven by early detection demand, while *Future Market Insights* estimates the screening and diagnostics market to be at $5.05–5.86 billion in 2025, expected to reach $10.5–11.36 billion by 2033–2035.

The wearable device integrates high-precision thermal sensors with AI-driven temperature-mapping to identify early-stage abnormalities in a non-invasive, radiation-free manner. The partnership combines CMET's R&D expertise with Lord's Mark's manufacturing scale and distribution strength, accelerating indigenous med-tech innovation.

KEY FEATURES AND ADVANTAGES

- **Convenient and Infrastructure-Light:** Usable in comfortable settings with minimal setup across hospitals, clinics, community centres, and homes.
- **Non-Radiative and Painless:** Eliminates radiation exposure and discomfort, improving screening compliance.
- **Advanced Thermal Sensors:** High-precision temperature-mapping powered by AI-driven analytics for real-time insights.
- **Privacy-First Design:** Discreetly wearable under clothing, ensuring dignity and user comfort.
- **Early Abnormality Detection:** Identifies early-stage thermal irregularities to support timely medical evaluation.
- **Portable and Scalable:** Lightweight, mobile solution enabling deployment across urban and underserved regions alike.

The device represents a significant advancement over traditional mammography by eliminating radiation exposure and discomfort, expanding access beyond hospital settings, and delivering reliable AI-driven detection insights.

With this initiative, Lord's Mark reinforces its long-term commitment to advancing accessible, AI-led healthcare solutions—positioning itself at the forefront of scalable preventive diagnostics in India.

Sachidanand Upadhyay, managing director, Lord's Mark Industries Limited, commenting on the partnership with CMET, said, "This collaboration marks a defining step in our journey to build globally competitive, indigenous healthcare technologies. By integrating CMET's scientific expertise with Lord's Mark's manufacturing strength, we are enabling a new paradigm in preventive diagnostics—non-invasive, AI-driven, and truly accessible. Our vision is to reduce barriers to early detection and empower women across India with safer, smarter screening solutions. This is not just a product initiative; it is a commitment to scalable, impact-led healthcare innovation."

mint Brand Focus

Lord's Mark Industries Limited looks to commercialise this product for mass breast cancer screening across India and take this product as 'gift' from this nation to the world by demonstrating that India is the only country to showcase this technology.

Lord's Mark Industries Limited will ensure that it makes the product so affordable that every woman in India and abroad will voluntarily get tested. This will not only create awareness, but also ensure that breast cancer can be curable by early detection.

For more information, visit - **http://lordsmark.com**

Disclaimer: The views expressed are those of the author/brand and not of Mint/ Hindustan Times and do not constitute medical advice.

RIL to make major investment in US refinery: Trump

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Donald Trump thanked Reliance for the investment. AP

In the wee hours of Wednesday, India time, President Donald Trump announced that Reliance Industries Ltd will partner America First Refining to set up the first new refinery in the US in nearly 50 years, in a deal valued at $300 billion.

Reliance Industries, however, had not confirmed the development as of press time. Shares initially surged but reversed to close 1.27% lower at ₹1,391.1 on the BSE, while the Sensex ended 1.72% down.

"Today I am proud to announce that America First Refining is opening the first new US oil refinery in 50 years in Brownsville, Texas," Trump wrote on Truth Social. "Thank you to our partners in India, and their largest privately held energy company, Reliance, for this tremendous investment."

Separately, America First Refining said that it received a "9-figure investment from a global supermajor at a 10-figure valuation," in February without naming the investor. (A 10-figure valuation ranges between $1-9.9 billion; a 9-figure investment between $100-999 million.) The company also said it had signed a binding 20-year off-take term sheet with the unnamed investor.

Reliance will partner America First Refining to set up the new refinery in the US in a deal valued at $300 billion

Reliance did not respond to *Mint's* requests for comment. The lack of confirmation from Reliance and the anonymity of America First's investor leaves unclear the Indian company's role in the project.

Trump's announcement comes as Reliance pursues a $10-billion investment to diversify from petroleum into renewable energy near its Jamnagar refinery, including solar panels, green hydrogen, and other clean technologies. Last month, chairman Mukesh Ambani also announced plans to invest ₹10 trillion over seven years in AI infrastructure, including data centres.

India's most valuable company with a market capitalization of ₹18.8 trillion, RIL runs the world's largest refinery complex in Jamnagar, processing 1.2 million barrels per day.

America First Refining added that construction would begin before June. The refinery is expected to process 60 million barrels of US light shale oil annually, totalling 1.2 billion barrels worth $125 billion over two decades. It would produce 50 billion gallons of refined products valued at $175 billion.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Airlines seek pilot duty time relief as longer routes bite

IndiGo and Air India Group said to have sought the relief following the West Asia conflict

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IndiGo and Air India Group approached the regulator after flight durations on several westbound routes increased. REUTERS

IndiGo and Air India Group have sought a temporary exemption from pilot duty hour requirements from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) after the West Asia conflict lengthened some international routes, pushing flight times beyond limits that normally require an additional pilot, according to a government official familiar with the matter.

Under India's Flight Duty Time Limitation (FDTL) rules, if a single-sector flight exceeds 10 hours of flight time—the maximum permitted duration for a two-pilot crew—airlines are required to deploy an additional pilot. This typically means operating the flight with an augmented crew consisting of a captain and two first officers.

The aviation safety regulator is conducting a safety assessment and could possibly agree to grant such exemptions, according to the official quoted above. *Mint* could not independently ascertain whether the exemption will be granted. An email sent to DGCA went unanswered.

The longer routings have already pushed several flights beyond the 10-hour limit. For instance, an Air India flight from Delhi to London, which earlier remained within the threshold, now takes between 10 hours 45 minutes and 11 hours 5 minutes, requiring the airline to deploy an additional pilot.

Before the West Asia crisis and the closure of Pakistani airspace, flights to Western destinations typically took 8.5-9 hours.

The request for relief also comes at a time when India's aviation sector is already struggling to hire enough pilots. New FDTL rules introduced last year require airlines to increase pilot numbers, including a restriction that allows pilots to operate flights landing between midnight and 6 a.m. only twice a week. Airlines had already deployed buffer pilots after the closure of Pakistani airspace.

As a result, airlines have been ramping up pilot hiring to comply with the new norms. However, flight durations stretching from around eight hours to more than ten hours on some sectors may further increase crew requirements.

Emails sent to IndiGo and Air India Group were unanswered till press time.

Airlines seek dispensations from the DGCA during times of crisis, war, and other exigencies. In the past, airlines have requested similar dispensations during events like the closure of Pakistani airspace, the Iran-Iraq war, and disruptions in Gulf airspace.

Airlines also seek case-by-case dispensations from FDTL rules during disruptions caused by weather or security events, such as during the 9/11 attacks and major snowstorms in the US, said Sanjay Lazar, aviation expert and CEO of Avialaz Consultants.

"This dispensation (if sought) by the airlines would be based on a detailed risk assessment by the DGCA on a case by case basis. Though I personally believe additional pilots are necessary in view of the uncertainty of the air space disruption and incidents of flight return like we saw over Ethiopia and Cairo recently," he said, adding that the inherent powers of the regulator permit it to issue dispensations if they feel safety norms are addressed.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

WAR IMPACT

WEST Asia conflict lengthened some international routes, pushing flight times beyond limits

AIRLINES need to deploy additional pilot if a single-sector flight exceeds 10 hours of flight time

THE longer routings have already pushed several flights beyond the 10-hour limit

THE request for relief comes when the aviation sector is already struggling to hire enough pilots

Sunjae Sharma elevated to a strategic role in Hong Kong.

Hyatt rejigs Asia Pacific leadership amid expansion

Devina Sengupta & Varuni Khosla
MUMBAI/ NEW DELHI

American hospitality chain Hyatt Hotels Corp. is reshuffling its leadership in Asia Pacific. Sunjae Sharma, current managing director for India and South-West Asia, will move into a leadership position for the Asia Pacific region at the company's Hong Kong hub, according to an internal email accessed by *Mint*.

Vikas Chawla will take over as president, India and South-West Asia from 1 April.

The email sent last week by David Udell, group president for Asia Pacific, said Sharma would take on broader regional responsibilities as the hotel chain sharpens its focus on growth across the region.

In the communication, Udell said India represents a significant long-term growth opportunity for Hyatt.

Hyatt has been expanding aggressively in Asia Pacific, particularly in markets such as India. In 2025, *Mint* reported that Hyatt Hotels planned to expand its footprint in India and South-West Asia to tap growing domestic demand for experience-led travel. The company aims to reach 100 hotels in the country by 2030. At the time, Sharma had said new hotel supply in India was being absorbed faster than expected despite international travel not having fully recovered, with domestic leisure and business travel continuing to drive demand.

Emails sent to Hyatt Hotels and Compass Group were unanswered till press time.

"Since joining Hyatt in 2002 at Grand Hyatt Delhi, Sunjae has been instrumental in expanding our footprint, strengthening operations, and developing a deep bench of hospitality talent in India... These changes are an important step in advancing our 'Strategic India Plan' and underscore our deep commitment and investment to India's future," Udell wrote.

Meanwhile, Chawla, who will be based in India and lead Hyatt's next phase of expansion across the domestic market, will report to Udell and oversee Hyatt's strategy, performance and expansion across the region.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Young savers drift, retirees prop deposits

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higher than classic fixed deposits. Investments in stocks and gold have been delivering far superior returns over the past few years.

"There is also easy access to these investment options on account of technology, internet, and the apps. We are also in the midst of a great deal of push by wealth advisors to invest in alternative assets and mutual funds, pulling money away from plain vanilla deposits," said Hathi.

While the worst deposit crunch may be behind them, local banks are still struggling to bring parity between their deposit and loan growth rate. The base of deposits is much larger—₹247.7 trillion—as against loans of ₹203.5 trillion and the growth rates are 11.2% and 13.4%, respectively.

While a like-to-like comparison is unavailable, younger investors have contributed to a higher share of net flows in the equity segment, per analysis by mutual fund industry body Association of Mutual Funds in India (Amfi) in its FY25 annual report.

Some experts said bank deposits, especially savings, earn even less than the rate of inflation.

Banks are struggling for deposit, loan growth parity. ISTOCKPHOTO

Deep Mukherjee, partner and director, risk management and data science, Boston Consulting Group, said that currently, for depositors, the benefit of parking money in liquid mutual funds, even after adjusting for taxes, usually works much better than parking it in term deposits or savings deposits. Liquid funds invest in short-term fixed debt instruments.

Indians have traditionally saved in banks and in fixed assets like real estate and gold. That is now changing

"Banks need to consider dynamic pricing of deposits, mindful of liquidity-adjusted market returns, to make it worthwhile for term and savings account depositors to stay, while reducing their own market-based lending and cost of the same," he said.

At most levels of inflation, saving deposits earn a negative real interest rate, said Mukherjee. "The advantage of moving from a bank savings rate or low-end deposits to a fixed income mutual fund is overwhelmingly in favour of mutual funds."

There are those who believe there is more to this shift than just return on investment.

"While bank deposits are taxed at the marginal rate, equity investments are subject to capital gains tax, allowing lower deductions. For senior citizens, with no other sources of income, bank deposits could even be tax free, depending on the interest earned," said Anil Gupta, senior vice president and co group financial sector ratings head at Icra

Indians have traditionally saved in banks and in fixed assets like real estate and gold. That is now changing as customers move to broader financial sector assets, a phenomenon known as the financialisation of savings.

The rising share of retirees also does not bode well for banks. These deposits are typically priced 50 bps higher than regular deposits. For instance, SBI pays 6.25% for retail deposits of one year to less than two years. The same tenor attracts 6.75% for senior citizens.

As depositors age and young savers diversify, banks may face higher funding costs and may need to look at more ways to attract savers.

Tech firms turn to influencers for job posts on social media

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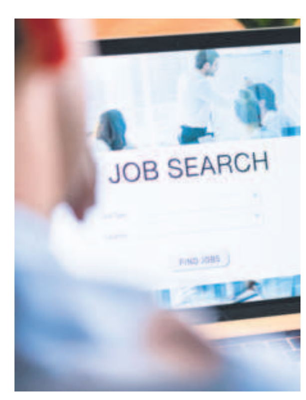
As India's job market battle intensifies, top tech firms are swapping staid job ads for influencer-marketing campaigns on Instagram, YouTube and LinkedIn. Creators with millions of followers now spotlight job openings and work cultures, turning a single video into a flood of thousands of applications.

Companies such as Atlassian, 7-Eleven GCC, Octa, EPAM Systems, ServiceNow, Intuit, ZS Associates, and Infosys are leading this charge, betting on niche influencers' social media reach to lure talent in a hyper-competitive landscape.

"For us, it's about visibility in the right places where top tech talent is consuming content. The primary goal is a long-term lift in technical sentiment," said Intuit, a US financial software company.

Companies use influencers to craft reputations for positive, attractive workplaces—targeting creators whose followers align with specific hiring needs, such as tech and AI professionals—to draw in candidates with maximum relevance and reach.



Creators eagerly amplify corporate gigs. ISTOCKPHOTO

Intuit's spokesperson explained that the company prioritizes technical authority over reach by partnering with influencers in the AI and software engineering sectors.

Creators eagerly amplify corporate gigs, blending recruitment campaigns with their personal brands for lucrative paydays.

"Influencers can make up to ₹10–20 lakh in one recruitment marketing campaign by making a video about the work culture at the company and selling its usage rights to the company," said Ishan Sharma, a tech creator with over 1.2 million Instagram followers.

Sharma noted that the popularity of recruitment marketing has surged, with opportunities now arriving as often as once every three months—though far less frequently than the 10–15 product marketing deals he lands on average each month.

Another creator from the tech and engineering domain, Arsh Goyal, who has over 486,000 followers on Instagram, highlighted that the payouts from advertising a company's job are no different from those for marketing its products.

"What changes is the call to action. Here, instead of asking people to buy the products, we are recommending suitable candidates to head to the careers portal and apply for the job," Goyal said.

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Markets sink over 1.6% as hopes of swift revival fade

FROM PAGE 1

serious challenge.

Financials and automobiles led the selling on Wednesday. Bajaj Finance (-4.9%), Axis Bank (-4.6%), Bajaj Finserv (-3.8%) were the biggest laggards, followed by Eicher Motors (-3.7%), M&M (-3.5%), and Bajaj Auto (-3.0%). Among NSE's sector indices, Nifty Auto was the worst performer, down 3.15%, while Nifty Private Bank was the second-worst performer, falling 2.4% on Wednesday.

According to BSE provisional data, foreign institutional investors (FIIs) net sold Indian equities worth ₹6,267 crore, whereas domestic institutional investors (DIIs) net purchased shares of ₹4,966 crore.

The rupee closed at 92.04 to the dollar, weakening from Tuesday's close of 91.80. Meanwhile, Brent crude spot rose 0.3% to $90.81 per barrel on Wednesday. Intraday, oil prices rallied 5%.

Vakil of HDFC Securities said higher crude oil and gas prices are squeezing profit margins for most Indian companies, as India imports over 85% of its energy needs, driving up input costs for sectors such as aviation, paints, tyres, chemicals, and logistics. These elevated costs often cannot be fully passed on to consumers due to weak pricing power amid slowing demand, leading analysts to slash earnings forecasts across autos, fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG), and industrials, he explained.

The International Energy Agency (IEA) has authorized a historic release of 400 million barrels of oil to stabilize global markets as Iran intensified its maritime campaign, striking three commercial vessels in the Strait of Hormuz.

Despite 125 basis points of prior rate cuts and keeping rates unchanged in February, Nomura, in an 11 March report, noted that the Reserve Bank of India's shift toward easier liquidity suggests room for further easing.

"That said, elevated oil prices since then are likely to dampen this dovishness, and we expect a policy hold from hereon."

On Wednesday, Nifty closed 1.6% lower at 23,866.85 and Sensex ended down 1.7% at 76,863.71. REUTERS

The brokerage said higher crude oil prices and energy disruptions pose upside risks to inflation, the fiscal deficit and the current account deficit, while also threatening growth. On the other hand, potential positives include an influx of capital, a recovery in exports, and a continued focus on reforms.

Not just the Indian economy, but the West Asia conflict poses wide-ranging risks to the listed universe too.

At the same time, some market participants noted that investors may increase allocations to select sectors such as upstream oil and gas producers, defence, shipping, and renewables or electric vehicles, which could potentially benefit from the evolving crisis.

SQUEEZING MARGINS

HIGHER crude oil prices are squeezing profit margins of cos, as India imports over 85% of energy needs

THESE elevated costs often cannot be fully passed on to consumers due to weak pricing power

In such a volatile environment, Vakil said leveraged positions should be appropriately hedged. But, "sharp market dislocations—when they arrive—historically offer compelling entry points for long-term investors with capital to deploy, and an opportunity to accumulate quality ideas at more attractive valuations," he added.

Meanwhile, Asian markets saw pockets of buying, but European markets declined.

Rahul Singh, chief investment officer of equities at Tata Asset Management, noted that West Asia tensions have raised the risk premium for Indian equities, fuelled by concerns over rising crude prices and a weakening rupee. "However, valuations have become more reasonable with the Nifty trading around 20 times earnings."

Despite global volatility, the consumer and pharma sectors remain resilient, while metals and energy benefit from higher commodity prices, he said. Improving credit growth supports banks, with Nifty 50 earnings projected to stay healthy at 15–17% through the next fiscal year.

VinFast hires veteran auto execs to scale India EV push

The firm recruited over half a dozen leaders from global automakers such as Hyundai, BMW

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VinFast has hired several senior Indian auto executives as it expands in India's EV car, scooter and bus markets. BLOOMBERG

Vietnamese electric vehicle (EV) maker VinFast has tapped a bevy of experienced Indian executives from local units of global automakers as it aims to rapidly expand in the country's battery-powered car, scooter and bus markets.

The company has recruited more than half a dozen senior leaders and executives with prior stints at firms such as Hyundai Motor Company, Honda Motor Co., Nissan Motor Co., Renault, BMW, and MG Motor over the past eight months, according to regulatory filings with the ministry of corporate affairs and the officials' social media profiles. VinFast's strategy mirrors the playbook of established foreign manufacturers that have previously scaled operations in the world's third-largest automobile market.

The leadership appointments include former Hyundai executives Tapan Ghosh as its chief executive officer and Bhartendu Singh as chief marketing officer, followed by ex-Honda Motorcycle and Scooter India executive Anurag Saxena as its deputy CEO.

The appointments were made even as VinFast's global headquarters remain closely involved in its India operations, with the three-member board of directors led by Pham Sanh Chau, managing director and chief executive VinGroup Asia.

Chau was present at many company announcements on financing partnerships and the achievement of five-star safety ratings in India over the past few months.

"This appears to be a conscious strategy. VinFast is hiring leaders who have previously helped global OEMs (original equipment manufacturers) successfully scale operations in India, particularly from companies like Hyundai that built strong localization and distribution models," Amit Kaushik, founder at Mobidx Ai, an automotive-focused analytics firm.

"Such leadership brings immediate credibility with investors and partners. In early-stage market entry, the strength of the management team often becomes a key signal for capital confidence, sometimes even before the product strategy fully plays out."

Queries mailed to VinFast remained unanswered till press time.

The composition of the operations team also includes professionals who have previously worked at global auto companies. VinFast's head of sales planning operations, Sudipta Ghosh, worked at Hyundai for eight years before joining the firm while senior network manager Manchit Handa had stints at firms like BMW, Honda, and Hyundai, among others.

Its aftersales teams along with product planning division also have executives that have previously worked at firms like Skoda India and Honda Cars.

The Vietnamese firm has pledged to invest around $2 billion in India, identifying the market as a key growth hub at a time when its bid in the North American market has faltered.

VinFast, which has helped conglomerate VinGroup group expand internationally and open operations in markets like the US, is not eyeing store expansion in North America for now, and is concentrating on Asian markets like India instead to help offset any loss.

Since September, it's selling two models in India—VF6 and VF7—and rose to the fourth spot in the EV car market in 2026. In the first two months, VinFast sold over 800 units. It assembles cars at its Thoothukudi plant with an annual capacity of 50,000 units and aims to expand to 300,000.

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EV LEADERSHIP PLAY

VINFAST is ranked fourth in India's EV car market in 2026, selling over 800 cars in first two months

DESPITE the key hirings, VinFast's global headquarters remains involved in India operations

ANALYSTS say experienced hands boost credibility with both investors and partners

THE company has pledged $2 billion in investment in India, positioning it as a key growth hub

Gas curbs, energy price surge squeeze tile makers' margins

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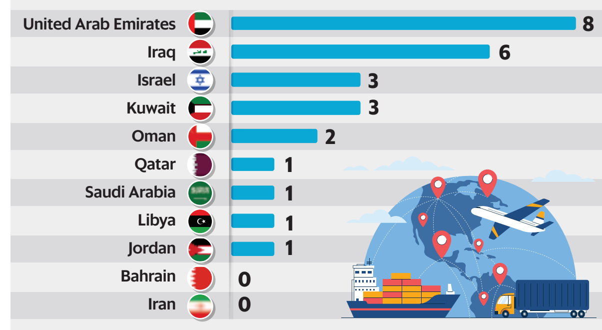
Limited exposure

The Middle East contributes only a modest portion of India's ceramic tile exports, led by demand from the UAE, Iraq, Israel and Kuwait.

Share of West Asian nations in India's ceramic tiles exports (in %)



Source: Prabhudas Lilladher

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PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

Rising tensions between the US and Iran have pushed global energy prices higher, bringing ceramic tile manufacturers under pressure. The industry that relies heavily on fuels such as natural gas and propane to fire kilns at high temperatures during the tile-making process feels the pinch of any spike in these fuel prices, which quickly feed into production costs.

So far in 2026, natural gas and propane prices have risen 8.3% and 18.7%, respectively. Power and fuel accounted for about 16% of Somany Ceramics' consolidated expenses and 12% of Asian Granito's in the December quarter. Kajaria and Somany are the biggest players by volume among listed firms.

India's ceramic tiles market reached 1,255.97 million sq mt (MSM) in 2025 and is projected to grow to 1,676.95 MSM by 2034, says IMARC Group, a global management consulting and market research firm.

Ceramic firms face a dilemma: raising prices to make up for the higher costs may reduce demand in a competitive environment and absorbing costs will cut margins, market participants said.

Tile makers face a dilemma—raise prices and risk weaker demand, or absorb higher costs and see margins shrink

FY25 annual reports show that Somany has a ceramic tile production capacity of 23.52 MSM per year, while Kajaria is at 34.15 MSM annually.

Morbi (Gujarat), accounting for 70-75% of India's total ceramic tile production and a significant share of exports, is witnessing heightened operational stress, said Prabhudas Lilladher report on 6 March.

"Of the 900 ceramic tile units in Morbi (370 fully gas-based and 530 dual-fuel units using gas and propane), shutdown levels have risen materially due to the fuel crisis arising with geopolitical tensions in the Middle East, with nearly half of gas-based units and 70% of dual-fuel units temporarily ceasing operations, underscoring severe stress in the cluster," the report said.

Arun Agarwal, vice president of Fundamental Research at Kotak Securities, said that if the Middle East crisis drags on, ceramic tile manufacturers could face margin pressure.

"Another key factor to watch is how much inventory companies have and how well their supply chains hold up," he explained. If the disruption lasts a month or longer, highly impacted players could see near-term earnings downgrades.

Shares of ceramic tile manufacturers have taken a hit since the US–Iran war erupted. Somany Ceramics led the losses with a steep 17.4% decline, followed by Nitco Ltd, which slipped 11.85%, and Asian Granito India slumped 11.3%. Meanwhile, Orient Bell fell 6.8%, while Kajaria Ceramics dropped 2.3%.

"Even before the US–Iran crisis, growth in the tile industry had already begun to lose momentum," said Keshav Lahoti, institutional research analyst at HDFC Securities. At the same time, the unorganised sector has been steadily eating into the market share of listed players, making it increasingly difficult for them to deliver market-beating returns, he added.

Valuations in the tile sector have corrected appropriately, reflecting subdued volume growth over the last few years, "a trend we expect to continue going forward," Lahoti said.

From a valuation perspective, the picture across listed tile companies is mixed. Kajaria Ceramics is trading at a price-to-earnings multiple of about 25.2 times, well below its five-year average of 35.6 times. Similarly, Somany Ceramics trades at around 35.74 times earnings, compared with its long-term average of 49.18 times, suggesting some cooling in valuations.

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Trump says the Iran war is nearly won but Israel has other ideas

Israel is sticking with its overarching goal of creating the conditions for regime change in Tehran

Anat Peled, Jared Malsin & Alexander Ward

President Trump's suggestions that the war with Iran might soon be over are bringing a new problem to the fore: Israel and the U.S. have different ideas on when to end the conflict and under what conditions.

Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu have spoken nearly every day since the war began, sometimes more than once a day. Netanyahu has also held conversations with Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Jared Kushner , the president's son-in-law and envoy for Iran. All those talks center on the current state of the war and how to end it, the U.S. officials said, as both countries try to bridge their differences in real time.

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There is some concern among White House officials that Israel wants the war to last after the U.S. expresses its desire to end the bombing campaign, the officials said. U.S. and Israeli officials say the Israeli message is it will stop its campaign in Iran whenever U.S. involvement stops. Trump has told aides he wants to end the war on his terms and, after brokering a ceasefire in last year's 12-day war, believes he can put a stop to the fighting when he wants, U.S. officials said.

"The end of America's involvement in this conflict will ultimately be determined by the commander in chief, when he feels the military objectives are fully met, and the threat of the rogue Iranian regime has been completely demolished," White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt said.

Despite their close coordination, differences in the Israeli and American approaches are emerging, with Israel continuing to track and kill top Iranian officials while broadening its range of targets to include the country's oil industry as it tries to force a change in leadership.

The U.S. also told Israel Monday that the administration was "not happy" with the attacks on Iranian energy facilities and told Israel not to do it again unless approved by Washington, according to U.S. sources. Axios earlier reported that the U.S. asked Israel to halt strikes on Iran's energy infrastructure.

And hours after Trump told a reporter the military campaign was "very complete, pretty much," Netanyahu reiterated his maximalist goals for the war.

"Our aspiration is to enable the Iranian people to cast off the yoke of tyranny; ultimately, it is up to them," Netanyahu said Tuesday. "There is no doubt that through the actions taken so far, we are breaking their bones and we are still active."

The different priorities in the air campaign were evident at the start. Elbridge Colby, the Pentagon's top policy official, told Congress last week that the airstrike that killed Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei was part of a series of "Israeli operations." Colby contrasted the Israeli attack with the "scoped and reasonable" objectives the U.S. was pursuing by focusing its strikes on Iran's missiles, drones and navy.

The U.S. administration has shifted its stated goals from the outset. Trump had initially called for regime change in Tehran, but told reporters Monday that the U.S. had already achieved most of its military goals, saying, "We're way ahead of schedule."


U.S. President Trump (Right) and Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu have spoken nearly every day since the war began. AFP

Like the U.S. military and senior Pentagon officials, Rubio has articulated a more limited set of goals, including setting back Iran's nuclear and missile programs. Air power alone has never removed a foreign government from power, a fact that U.S. military planners and analysts acknowledge.

The Pentagon also acknowledged the divergent approaches to the air campaign in a briefing Tuesday by Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and Gen. Dan Caine, the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. Hegseth said the Israeli military has been a good partner but added, "Where they have different objectives, they have pursued them." He was responding to a question about Israel's strikes on fuel depots near Tehran, which Sen. Lindsey Graham , a South Carolina Republican and Trump ally, has criticized as a move that may alienate the Iranian public.

Meanwhile, the Iranian regime has shown some resilience in recent days, selecting a new supreme leader and extending its blockade of Persian Gulf oil.

"Trump may be learning the oldest lesson of human conflicts: It is much easier to start a war than to end one," said Ali Vaez , the Iran project director at International Crisis Group. "By hinting at stopping the bombing without a credible diplomatic off-ramp, he risks creating the worst of both worlds—Iran has every incentive to keep using its leverage over the Strait of Hormuz, while Israel may see no reason to stop its own campaign."

The growing economic damage from the war is further diverging U.S. and Israeli interests.

Netanyahu has for years called for the removal of the Iranian regime and spoke about the threat posed by the country's nuclear program to Israel. After a series of successful military operations against Iran's allies in the region, he saw an opening last year, launching a 12-day war that further set back Iran militarily.

While the U.S. shares that goal, it has a broader set of interests in the region, including its role as the main military partner of the energy-rich Gulf states, some of which are now seeing their oil-and-gas exports bottled up by Iran and their cities and industrial infrastructure under attack.

Iran's blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, which pushed oil above $100 a barrel this week, is a sign that turmoil unleashed by the conflict could require yet another set of military solutions.

Trump on Monday said that "if needed" the U.S. Navy could escort oil tankers through the strait, through which about a fifth of the world's oil typically passes. That could keep the U.S. in the conflict longer than planned. On Monday, Trump threatened an escalation of attacks to unblock the channel, saying on Truth Social that the U.S. would bomb targets that "will make it virtually impossible for Iran to ever be built back, as a Nation, again—Death, Fire, and Fury will reign upon them."

Despite their close coordination, differences in the American and Israeli approaches are emerging

Israel is hoping the U.S. stays in the fight longer.

"Bibi's dream and I think Israel's dream for decades is a joint war to topple the Islamic Republic. But to rely on Trump for anything is always a dubious undertaking," said Chuck Freilich , a former deputy national security adviser in Israel and senior researcher at the Institute for National Security Studies, a Tel Aviv think tank, referring to Netanyahu by his nickname.

The two leaders are speaking to very different domestic audiences, with public polling revealing gaps between the two countries.

A poll conducted by the INSS in early March showed 82% of Israelis support the war. The issue is of utmost importance to Netanyahu, who is likely betting on a boost in polling from the war in the lead-up to Israeli elections expected later this year.

The Israeli public is also exposed to Iran's missile threat in a way that Americans aren't. It takes about nine minutes for a ballistic missile to fly from Iran to Israel, but Tehran doesn't have the capability to strike the American homeland with a long-range missile. The U.S. Defense Intelligence Agency projected in May that Iran could deploy as many as 60 ocean-spanning missiles by 2035 if it decided to adapt a system it has been developing for putting satellites into low-Earth orbit for intercontinental ballistic missiles instead.

Israel is well aware that Trump could end the war at any moment and is fighting as if every day is the last, said a person briefed on the operation. Israel wants more time, but is aware of the pressures Trump is facing at home to end the war, the person said.

The Trump administration's shifting objectives have damped public backing for the war in the U.S., with a range of opinion polls showing that a minority supports it. Trump is facing criticism from some Democrats and the right of his party, who want him to pursue a more isolationist vision of his foreign policy. He initially campaigned against the U.S. invasion of Iraq and in years past promised to end America's "forever wars" in the Middle East.

Some of Trump's advisers have privately urged him to look for an exit plan amid spiking oil prices and concerns that a lengthy conflict could spark political backlash, The Wall Street Journal reported Monday.

U.S. special envoy Steve Witkoff said he is likely to travel to Israel next week to coordinate with Israeli leaders on the continuing military campaign in Iran.

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The world needs these two Middle East pipelines now more than ever

Joe Wallace & Rebecca Feng

Two pipelines built just for the occasion—one in Saudi Arabia and one in the United Arab Emirates—bypass the Strait of Hormuz. They are the only ways to get a significant amount of oil out of the Persian Gulf into world markets.

The pipes can't replace the flows carried by tanker ships , but their use is almost all that is preventing an even worse crisis from unfolding. Saudi Arabia in particular is pumping as much crude as possible through its pipeline to its Red Sea port of Yanbu, built in the early 1980s when the Iran-Iraq War threatened shipping in the Persian Gulf.

"While we have faced disruptions in the past, this one by far is the biggest crisis the region's oil-and-gas industry has faced," said Amin Nasser , Saudi Aramco's chief executive, on Tuesday.

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The shipping blockage has made Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline one of the most critical pieces of infrastructure in the world economy. The state oil producer expects to send a maximum of 7 million barrels of oil through the 746-mile-long pipeline within a few days, Nasser said.

About 2 million barrels of oil are dedicated to Saudi refiners, leaving 5 million barrels that could reach global markets each day. That is equal to most of Saudi Arabia's crude shipments through the strait in the run-up to the war, according to the International Energy Agency.

It is a big test of the infrastructure. The pipe has never run at full capacity for an extended period, the IEA said. And it doesn't fix the whole problem: Aramco sends 800,000 barrels daily of petroleum products through the strait, which can't be rerouted. Plus, there is the oil stranded in Kuwait, Iraq and Bahrain.

To boot, Iran has attacked energy infrastructure across the Gulf in an attempt to drive up prices for American voters. Analysts say there isn't much to stop Tehran from targeting the Saudi and Emirati pipelines.

As long as oil is flowing through them, at least some crude can reach buyers while more than 1,000 ships are stuck in the Persian Gulf. The smaller Emirati pipeline transports crude from Abu Dhabi to the port of Fujairah on the Gulf of Oman.

"If you suddenly see two very large crude carriers coming out of Yanbu and one out of Fujairah, there is a psychological effect that at least some oil is coming out," said Adi Imsirovic, a former trader and lecturer at the University of Oxford. "What really worries me is that it's not particularly difficult to target those pipelines."

Crude prices fell Tuesday , extending a retreat sparked by President Trump's comment that the war would be over "very soon." Brent, the global benchmark, is still 27% higher than on the eve of the war.

One sign buyers are desperate to get their hands on crude that can bypass Hormuz is the fact that prices on either side of the strait have gone haywire. Crude loaded from Oman trades at a premium to a flavor known as Dubai, which can't be diverted from the port of Fateh on the wrong side of the passage.

A tanker belonging to daredevil Greek shipowner George Prokopiou is among the few Western ships to have sailed


The pipes can't replace tanker ships , but their use is almost all that is preventing an even worse crisis from unfolding. REUTERS

out through the passage since the war began, according to data firm Kpler. It was carrying Saudi crude and sailed through Hormuz with its signal off.

Oil flows through the waterway ticked higher Monday, Goldman Sachs analysts said in a note, counting the number of vessels at 20% of prewar daily rates. The bank cautioned that the data can be noisy and that tanker traffic has become hard to track as vessels turn off their transponders to avoid detection.

To boot, Iran has attacked energy infrastructure across the Gulf in an attempt to drive up prices for American voters

Other European tanker executives with ships in the region said they still didn't feel confident sending them through the strait.

Snaking through dunes, mountains and lava fields, the pipeline carries oil from huge fields in eastern Saudi Arabia to the country's Red Sea Coast. It is roughly the same length as the Trans-Alaska Pipeline.

Around 7,000 workers toiled on the four-year project, overseen by a division of Mobil Oil , an in-house Aramco newsletter reported in 1983, two years after the first shipment. For a parallel pipe dedicated to natural-gas byproducts, workers blasted a trench across the Arabian Peninsula with 2,000 tons of explosives.

The artery was conceived as a way to dodge the Persian Gulf and bring Saudi exports closer to Western markets. These days, most Saudi oil exports head to Asia.

Even more oil might have been able to head out via the Red Sea had another pipeline not fallen hostage to regional hostilities. At the start of 1990, Iraq and Saudi Arabia opened a massive pipeline that was supposed to take Baghdad's crude all the way to Yanbu. Seven months later, Saddam Hussein invaded Kuwait and the pipeline never took off.

Daily exports out of Yanbu have risen by 2 million barrels a day over the past week, said Vikas Dwivedi, global energy strategist at Macquarie. He estimates that the pipe was running at 50% to 60% capacity as of Monday.

A smaller, newer Emirati pipeline, partially built by a subsidiary of state-owned China National Petroleum Corp., runs from Habshan in Abu Dhabi to Fujairah on the Gulf of Oman. It carries up to 1.8 million barrels a day and was already pushing about 1.1 million barrels through before the war, according to the IEA.

Crude loadings at both Yanbu and Fujairah have jumped. Petrobras, the Brazilian state-backed oil company, said Saudi Arabia has satisfied its commitment by sending oil through the pipeline. The only problem for Petrobras now, said its chief executive , is the increase in shipping costs.

A back-of-the-envelope calculation suggests that even with the pipeline flows, there are still around 10 million barrels that will be stuck in the Persian Gulf, according to analytics firm Sparta Commodities. "We've basically solved half of the problem," said Neil Crosby at Sparta.

Though safer than heading into the Persian Gulf, loading oil in the Red Sea and at Fujairah isn't risk free. The Emirati port was damaged by an attempted drone attack last week, which prompted some fuel suppliers there to back out of contracts.

Iran-aligned Houthi rebels in Yemen launched dozens of attacks on commercial ships in 2024. Though they haven't restarted the campaign during the current war, maritime security analysts at U.K.-based Ambrey are advising ships tied to the U.S. and Israel to avoid the Red Sea.

Iran itself built a pipeline to get around the Persian Gulf to the port of Jask on the Gulf of Oman. A supertanker capable of carrying 2 million barrels of crude loaded at the port over the weekend, according to Kpler. It was only the third cargo to set sail from Jask since 2021.

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IEA proposes largest ever oil release from strategic reserves

Matthew Dalton, Bojan Pancevski & Laurence Norman

PARIS

The International Energy Agency has proposed the largest release of oil reserves in its history to bring down crude prices that have soared during the U.S.-Israel war with Iran , officials familiar with the matter said.

The release of 400 million barrels of oil would more than double the agency's biggest prior release, when IEA member countries in 2022 put 182 million barrels on the market after Russia launched its full-scale invasion of Ukraine, the officials said. The proposal was circulated at an emergency meeting of energy officials from the IEA's 32 member countries on Tuesday.

Countries are expected to decide on the proposal Wednesday. It could be adopted if none objects, but even one country's protests could delay the plan, officials said.

French President Emmanuel Macron will host a video conference call at 10 a.m. ET with leaders of the Group of Seven advanced economies to discuss ways to mitigate the energy situation, France's Elysee Palace said.

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The IEA proposal is intended to counter the massive disruption caused by the near-total closure of the Strait of Hormuz , the narrow waterway that connects the Persian Gulf to global markets. Roughly one-fifth of the world's oil supply moves through the strait every day and the threat of attacks on tankers by Iran have brought shipments to a near standstill.

Iranian attacks on oil tankers


The release of 400 million barrels of oil would more than double the agency's biggest prior release. BLOOMBERG

traveling through the strait are the kind of scenario that led Western nations and their allies to create the IEA in 1974 in the wake of the Arab oil embargo. The agency, a club of Western nations and their allies, sets guidelines for how much crude member countries must keep in their reserves and coordinates releases to protect economies from oil market turmoil.

Since Feb. 28 when the U.S. and Israel first began their strikes on Iran, the price of oil has soared as much as 40%, breaching $100 before falling this week as traders closely track statements from President Trump on how long the war will last. Oil ended Tuesday under $84, but the price of fuels such as diesel has continued to skyrocket .

Economists have warned that a sustained run-up in oil prices risks creating inflation and a stock market correction , in addition to pain at the pump for drivers.

IEA members hold 1.2 billion barrels in public stocks, plus another 600 million in mandatory commercial inventories, IEA Executive Director Fatih Birol said Monday. By rough calculation, that is around 124 days worth of lost supply from the Gulf.

Previous releases from strategic reserves have had mixed results.

IEA members did two releases in quick succession after Russia invaded Ukraine in early 2022. The move at first caused oil prices to rise 20% as traders saw the release as a sign the oil crisis was more serious than they had anticipated. Analysts say the releases eventually helped bring prices down.

A particularly successful release took place in 1991 when then-President George H.W. Bush prepared for Operation Desert Storm by ordering what was then the first ever drawdown of the Strategic Petroleum Reserve on the same night a U.S.-led coalition attacked Iraq. IEA members joined in releasing more oil from stockpiles in a plan they had put in place ahead of the invasion.

Prices fell more than 20% on the first day of the U.S.-led assault. By the time coalition forces entered Iraq and Kuwait in February, oil from the SPR was on the market.

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NEWS IN NUMBERS

140
THE NUMBER of US service members wounded in the war with Iran as of Wednesday, most of them with minor injuries, according to the Pentagon.

50,000
THE NUMBER of jobs Volkswagen plans to cut in Germany by 2030, as profits slump amid rising costs, US tariffs and competition from Chinese EV makers.

₹144
THE PRICE hike on a 19kg commercial LPG cylinder in India, as oil firms raise cooking gas rates amid supply disruptions from the US-Israel-Iran conflict.

300
THE NUMBER of serious adverse-event reports that US FDA inspectors found Novo Nordisk had failed to submit on time for Ozempic and other drugs.

9 mn
THE NUMBER of women removed from Maharashtra's Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana, slashing beneficiaries to 15.3 million, with 283,000 names dropped in Beed alone.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Rupee falls 16 paise to 92.01 vs US dollar


The rupee was weighed down by a sharp rise in crude prices and a stronger greenback. REUTERS

The rupee declined by 16 paise to settle at 92.01 against the US dollar on Wednesday, weighed down by a sharp rise in global crude oil prices and a stronger greenback as the war in West Asia raged on.

Foreign institutional investor (FII) outflows and weak sentiment in the domestic equity markets further pressured the local unit, according to forex traders.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 91.92 against the US dollar and traded in the range of 91.85-92.06 before settling at 92.01. The rupee staged a strong recovery from its record low against the US dollar on Tuesday, gaining 36 paise to settle at 91.85.

"The rupee declined on weak domestic markets and overnight recovery in crude oil prices. Risk-off sentiments in the global markets and FII outflows may continue to weigh on the rupee. Markets will also watch out for geopolitical developments in West Asia," Anuj Choudhary, research analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

The dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading 0.14% higher at 98.96. PTI


AP

SC allows first ever case of passive euthanasia

Centre should consider bringing comprehensive legislation on passive euthanasia, top court says

PTI
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NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday allowed the withdrawal of artificial life support to a 32-year-old man, in a coma for more than 13 years, saying that the government should consider bringing comprehensive legislation on passive euthanasia.

In the top court's first ever order on the emotive issue, a bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and K.V. Viswanathan directed AIIMS-Delhi to ensure life support is withdrawn with a tailored plan so that dignity is maintained. Passive euthanasia is the intentional act of letting a patient die by withholding or withdrawing life support or the treatment to keep them alive.

The patient, Ghaziabad's Harish Rana, who was a B.Tech student at Panjab University and a football-loving sporty young man, suffered head injuries after falling from the fourth floor of his paying guest accommodation in 2013 and has been in a coma since.

"In the facts and circumstances of the present case, we record our satisfaction that the twin legal requirements for the withdrawal and withholding of medical treatment have been unequivocally met. First, it is established that the Clinically Assisted Nutrition and Hydration currently being administered to the applicant constitutes 'medical treatment'.

"Secondly, it has been conclusively determined that the continued administration of the same is no longer in the 'best interests' of the applicant. In light of the unanimous consensus arrived at by the parents/next of kin and the constituted medical boards respectively, we are of the opinion that the medical treatment ought not to be prolonged any further," the bench said in a 338-page judgment.

"The right to die with dignity is inseparable from the right to receive quality palliative and End Of Life care. It is imperative to ensure that the withdrawal process is not marred by pain, agony, or suffering," it added.

The top court noted Rana survived only through clinically administered nutrition via percutaneous endoscopic gastrostomy tubes and medical boards unanimously concluded that continuation of treatment merely prolonged biological existence without any possibility of recovery.

Urea cos shut plants as war hits LNG flows

Some urea companies in India have shut down plants or moved up annual maintenance after Qatari supplies of liquefied natural gas (LNG), a key feedstock, were suspended due to the Iran war.

Manufacturers, including top producer Indian Farmers Fertiliser Cooperative Ltd, have either halted some of their facilities or started routine upkeep, according to people familiar with the matter.

Restarting a paused plant could take as long as a month, provided LNG supplies resume, they added, asking not to be named because the matter is private.

LNG is the primary feedstock for urea production, serving as an energy source and a key input in making the world's most widely used fertilizer. Gas supplies to India's fertilizer industry are currently about 70% of their requirement, the people added. BLOOMBERG

Sebi eases PARS compliance norms

In a move aimed at easing compliance requirements, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) on Wednesday relaxed certification norms for persons associated with research services (PARS), allowing sales staff, relationship managers and other non-research personnel to qualify through a lighter certification module. "Based on the feedback from market participants and as a step towards ease of doing business, it has been decided to specify a lighter NISM certification module for PARS, such as sales staff, relationship managers and other staff, who perform sales and other non-core services, have client contact but are not directly associated or involved in research related aspects," Sebi said. PTI

Banks told the RBI that the new rules would require major changes to their systems and data formats. MINT

Lenders push back on FX trade reporting

Global lenders pushed back against a proposal by India's central bank for more reporting of offshore rupee trades, according to people familiar with the matter. Banks told the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) the proposal could breach client confidentiality and conflict with data and reporting rules in other jurisdictions, the people said, asking not to be named discussing private matters. They submitted written feedback by the 9 March deadline through two international financial industry associations, the people said.

In a 16 February draft of the rules, the RBI asked banks to report more details of derivative trades linked to the rupee that are conducted outside the country. Lenders would need to report at least 70% of such transactions—which have grown to an average of more than $149 billion a day—within a year of the rules taking effect.

Banks told the RBI that the new rules would require major changes to their systems, data formats and legal agreements, given the scale of daily trading in the offshore currency market, the people said. Some lenders said they may only be able to share information for clients who explicitly consent to the disclosures, the people said. BLOOMBERG

SBI and MUFG Bank will collaborate on financing M&As, and aviation and real estate projects. REUTERS

SBI, MUFG Bank tie up to finance deals

State Bank of India (SBI) has entered a strategic partnership with Japan's MUFG Bank to collaborate on financing mergers and acquisitions (M&As), and aviation and real estate projects to support Indian and global clients, the lenders said in a joint statement on Wednesday.

The agreement comes after the Reserve Bank of India issued the final guidelines for banks to finance mergers and acquisitions on 13 February, executing a significant regulatory shift that's expected to boost deal funding by domestic lenders. Under the new rules, banks can fund up to 75% of a total value of a deal, but must ensure their total lending for such acquisitions does not exceed 20% of their core capital.

This deal is important as it deepens India-Japan financial ties and supports cross-border corporate activity. SUBHANA SHAIKH

DCGI bars indirect ads on obesity drugs

The Drugs Controller General of India (DCGI) has directed all pharmaceutical manufacturers and importers to immediately stop surrogate, or indirect, promotion of prescription drugs, particularly targeting new weight-loss and metabolic disorder drugs, according to an advisory reviewed by *Mint*. The directive, issued by the Central Drugs Standard Control Organization on 11 March, signals a significant regulatory shift to protect public health from misleading marketing practices. The advisory comes after reports surfaced that drugmakers may be engaging in indirect promotional activities through social media, influencer engagements and corporate campaigns. PRIYANKA SHARMA

Rahejas sell flat in Worli for ₹121 crore

Ravi Raheja, group president of real estate firm K Raheja Corp., and his wife Sumati Raheja, have sold a 6,772 sq. ft apartment at Raheja Artesia, a super-luxury tower in Mumbai's Worli for ₹121 crore.

The sale to Shree Dhootapapeshwar Ltd comes amid a wave of record-setting deals in the city's most expensive real estate strip.

The apartment, on the 44th floor, has an additional 367 sq. ft balcony space or open terrace. On a per-square-foot basis, factoring in the outdoor space, the transaction worked out to around ₹1.7 lakh per sq. ft. The apartment comes with six car parks.

Raheja Artesia is a well-known luxury project by K. Raheja Corp Homes that has been completed and delivered. Shree Dhootapapeshwar Ltd, a Mumbai-based company, makes and sells Ayurvedic products and supplements. MADHURIMA NANDY

AI boom sparks a new chip problem for car cos

FROM PAGE 1

above said on the condition of anonymity.

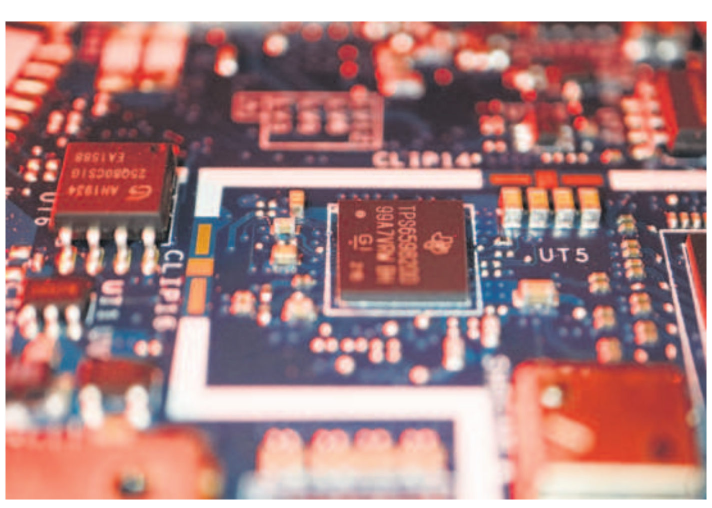
The issue was earlier flagged to analysts by Mahindra and Mahindra Ltd (M&M), which makes electric cars, and e-two-wheeler manufacturer Ather Energy Ltd.

"Memory chips are something that is a supply chain risk/price sensitive thing because shortage obviously is driving premiums in memory chips," M&M executive director Rajesh Jejurikar told analysts and investors on an 11 February earnings call. "So, a memory chip is something which is a watch-out across the portfolio right now. That's the new rare, rare earth, let's call it that."

However, Jejurikar assured that the situation was under control. "We are buying in the market, we are paying a premium and we have a set of mitigating actions," he said. "We are covered in the short run but it's almost like going back to semiconductors of covid... the risk could be quite severe."

Then, last week, during a meeting with analysts of Nuvama Institutional Equities, Bengaluru-based Ather Energy highlighted memory chips' inflation owing to supply crunch as one of the near-term headwinds to the business.

Queries sent to automakers Maruti Suzuki, Tata Motors PV, Hyundai Motor India, Ola Electric, Hero MotoCorp, Honda Motorcycle and Scooter India, Bajaj Auto, TVS Motor Company and auto suppliers like Samvardhana Motherson, Sona Comstar, and Bosch remained unanswered till press time.


As chipmakers shift manufacturing capacity toward HBM, supplies of conventional memory chips used in cars are tightening. REUTERS

Micron Technology in the US and South Korea's Samsung and SK Hynix are focusing their manufacturing lines on making HBM chips, used in graphic processing units that Nvidia sells for AI data centres.

"There is definitely a shortage of DRAM and NAND chips (memory chips used in vehicles)... which is likely to affect the automotive industry all through 2026, and at least partially in 2027 as well," Ashok Chandak, president, India Electronics and Semiconductor Association, said.

"This could also be amplified by large tech firms pushing chip supply chains to cater to their AI demand, and large industrial conglomerates over-ordering and advance-ordering memory chips for industrial uses, which could affect small auto firms," he added.

The older generation chips, used by automakers, are not being prioritized for production, leading to a supply crunch and high prices.

Memory chips in vehicles, while minuscule in share of overall content, are critical as they help in storing and accessing data, and are used in infotainment systems, advanced driver assistance systems (ADAS), engine control units, and battery management systems, among others. Their shortage risks putting vehicle production out of gear.

"With the current supply chain catering heavily to HBM chips, the market is skewered because HBM chips have much larger die sizes, lower yields, and require advanced packaging, which means that they take longer to make," said Kanishka Chauhan, senior principal analyst of emerging trends and technologies at Gartner. HBM chips are more expensive and provide better margins and returns, he said.

"Over time, there is likely to be a concerted push to move industrial systems to newer generation memory chips...in line with the cyclical process in which this industry works. Until this cycle resolves, there is likely to be a cycle of supply shortage for all kinds of memory but especially the legacy memory chips, which could affect various parts of the downstream industries," he said.

Even as suppliers have begun to urge automakers to upgrade vehicle technology architecture to support newer-generation chips, industry executives and experts suggest that the effort has already begun.

"For automakers, this increases the urgency to upgrade their electronic and software architecture," Harshvardhan Sharma, group head of automotive technology & innovation at Nomura Research Institute Consulting & Solutions India, said.

"Moving toward centralized or domain-controller architectures allows OEMs (original equipment manufacturers) to use more advanced chips efficiently and reduce dependence on a large number of lower-end components," Sharma noted, adding that a typical memory chip content in a vehicle is still relatively modest, typically $10-20 in entry-level vehicles and up to $40-80 in more advanced ones.

An upgrade to vehicle technology systems can allow companies to achieve two things, as per experts and executives. One, they can use the widely produced next generation chips. And second, they can reduce the number of chips required, which can ease supply pressure.

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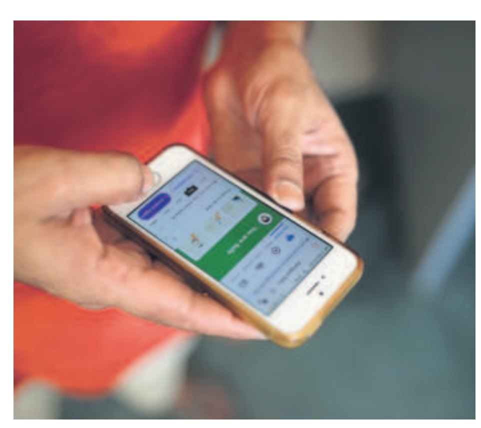
In its new avatar, the Aarogya Setu app will focus on secure medical history management AP

Aarogya Setu app set for reboot

The government is set to repurpose and relaunch the pandemic-era Aarogya Setu mobile application as a personal health record (PHR) app, allowing patients to digitally access and share their health records while preventing any single health application from gaining a monopoly, two government officials aware of the development said.

The relaunch aims to move Aarogya Setu away from being a covid-era tracking tool and position it as a supplement to India's digital health infrastructure. It involves a complete overhaul of the app's core functionality, with the contact-tracing feature permanently discontinued and all associated data deleted to address privacy concerns, they said.

The app's contact-tracing feature used Bluetooth and GPS to alert users if they had been near someone infected with covid-19.

In its new avatar, the app will focus on secure medical history management, with functionalities such as smart reports and appointment reminders, helping users to seamlessly create and link their 14-digit unique Ayushman Bharat Health Account identity using Aadhaar-based authentication. PRIYANKA SHARMA

Porsche pivots to cost-cutting

Porsche AG's new chief executive Michael Leiters plans to cut spending at the German manufacturer and add models positioned above the 911 to bolster profits.

The moves are meant to counter tariffs, slumping sales in China and Porsche's costly revamp of overly ambitious plans for electric vehicles. Still, sales this year are set to decline to at best €36 billion ($41.9 billion), the luxury-car maker said Wednesday. Leiters, who took over from Oliver Blume in January, is seeking to revive performance after a torrid year.

Porsche's investments will peak this year and then gradually decline as it reduces research and development spending, including on EVs. Porsche will cut management layers as well as hierarchies, it said. Leiters will engage labor leaders in discussions over a fresh round of savings measures. The company is also looking at models and derivatives positioned above its two-door sports cars and the Cayenne sport utility vehicle to underpin margins. BLOOMBERG

A NEW CHAPTER OPENS FOR BOOKS IN INDIA

Digital fatigue, litfests, bookstores and a new generation of readers are fuelling a revival in reading

Neha Bhatt
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GURUGRAM

A reading session of the Silent Book Club at Sunder Nursery, New Delhi, on 14 February.

In January, crowds spilled out of festival tents on Kozhikode's seafront, jostling their way from one venue to another. The ninth edition of the Kerala Literature Festival (KLF) pulled in over 700,000 people. Among the 580 speakers this year were astronaut Sunita Williams, Wikipedia founder Jimmy Wales and award-winning author Kiran Desai.

The massive turnout led to the festival bookstore being expanded from one outlet to three, with sales crossing ₹2 crore over five days, excluding revenue from souvenirs and other merchandise. The estimated economic impact generated for hotels, transport services, restaurants, artisans and local businesses is pegged at ₹130 crore, according to KLF officials.

It was not an isolated spike. The Kolkata Book Fair, which concluded in early February, drew a record footfall of 3.2 million visitors, up from 2.7 million last year, with total sales touching ₹27 crore, the organizers said.

At the New Delhi World Book Fair in January, the organizers reported a 20% rise in attendance, while several publishers clocked their highest-ever revenue at the eight-day event. At the 19th edition of the Jaipur Literature Festival in January, co-director William Dalrymple noted that over 44,000 books were sold; authors faced some of the longest signing queues in the festival's history.

The numbers tell a story: India's book business is booming.

Publishers, bookstore owners, literature festival directors and industry watchers are unequivocal—the current moment appears to be a structural upswing rather than a post-pandemic blip.

According to NielsenIQ BookData and GfK Entertainment's international study for the first eight months of 2025, more than half of the 19 markets surveyed saw higher book sales revenue than during the same period last year. India led the growth with a 28.6% increase, followed by Brazil (10.8%), Colombia (9.6%) and Portugal (8.4%). During the same period in 2024, India's revenue grew by 18.3%, and in 2023 (full year) it was relatively slow at 7.1%.

India's book exports rose from about ₹2,454 crore in fiscal year 2024 (FY24) to ₹2,603 crore in FY25, according to publishing and printing research firm IPPstar. Analysis by market intel platform Grand View Horizon estimates that India's book market generated revenue of $10.37 billion in 2024 and is expected to reach $16.42 billion by 2033, with fantasy the fastest-growing segment.

"After a prolonged period of being locked down during the pandemic, people wanted to step out, browse, discover new voices and new genres. And what better place to do this than bookstores, which saw a renewal of sorts, as well," said Riti Jagoorie, managing director of publisher Hachette India. "We've seen phenomenal growth from 2021 to 2025. We hit sales of over ₹110 crore in 2025 and delivered our best profit performance thus far. We doubled our sales at the Kolkata Book Fair, and we were 12% ahead of last year at the World Book Fair."

> India's book market generated revenue of $10.37 billion in 2024 and is expected to reach $16.42 billion by 2033, with fantasy the fastest growing segment.

Hachette India's annual sales in 2019, the year before the pandemic, stood at ₹45 crore.

DIGITAL DETOX

With digital fatigue setting in after years of pandemic-induced screen overload, reading seems to be in vogue once again. "Gadgets have only so much of a lifeline. There's been a realization about the kind of entertainment people are seeking, and as a result, reading has diversified. We see an overall upswing in many categories: cookery, health, spirituality," said Kapish Mehra, managing director of Rupa Publications and co-founder of Aleph Book Company. "We have even added two new imprints—Moonstone, dedicated to children's books, and Sanskriti Press, focused on spirituality and religion, post-pandemic."

There's a sense globally that we've hit peak digital overload. Attention spans are fragmented and people are craving deeper engagement again, said Anish Chandy, founder of Labyrinth Literary Agency. The momentum has also been fuelled by the significant buzz around big-ticket books by Indian authors that have a global platform, including Arundhati Roy for *Mother Mary Comes to Me*, Kiran Desai for *The Loneliness of Sonia and Sunny* and Banu Mushtaq for *Heart Lamp*.

The Indian publishing industry is in a phase of steady growth, driven by strong readership and continued demand for quality content across genres, said Manoj Satti, senior vice president– product, sales and marketing, Penguin Random House India. "Our experience over the past year has been particularly positive, with double-digit year-on-year growth in sales at major book fairs," he added. "The national and global recognition for Indian authors reflects sustained creative depth and growing international interest in Indian stories. Awards are helping bring wider visibility and strong readerships."

While English language publishing continues to do well, regional language publishing is seeing renewed energy. The Malayalam novel *Ram C/O Anandhi* by Akhil P. Dharmajan, for example, sold 300,000 copies in 12 months. There are more takers for versions in other languages, too.

"There is a renewed interest in translations, with readers going out of their way to seek out regional and local publishers, periodicals and books. The non-fiction boom is visible in books about food and culture too," said Aparajitha Sankar, owner of the independent, family-run Bengaluru bookstore Atta Galatta, which focuses on stocking Indian writing in English and books in over 12 Indian languages.

"There is a huge misconception that people are reading less. Our footfall has increased 20–25% since 2024," she said.

CATCHING THEM YOUNG

While fiction once accounted for about 21-22% of the market and non-fiction dominated at nearly 60%, there is now a visible tilt towards fiction, driven largely by younger readers, said Penguin Random House India's Satti.

A new mass market is also being shaped by influencer-authored books, such as those by YouTuber and actor Prajakta Koli, whose debut novel *Too Good to Be True* topped Indian adult fiction charts last year, selling over 200,000 copies.

The definition of 'celebrity' in the books business has widened. "It used to mean Bollywood stars, cricketers or politicians. Now it could be someone in baby care, wellness or finance. The book industry mirrors what's happening in society, and society is creating new kinds of celebrities," said Chandy.

Social media has changed both who gets marketed and, increasingly, who gets published. "Publishers are more open to authors who come with a sizeable following, especially in categories like self-help or practical non-fiction," he added.

A younger demographic is driving much of this growth. According to the Nielsen Books & Consumer Study (July 2024-March 2025), readers aged 16–24 account for approximately 37% of print book purchases, making Gen Z one of the single largest readership cohorts in the country.

"The interest level in books is also fuelled to some extent by shows and films. Before 'Bridgerton', for example, we were selling 700-900 copies a year of Julia Quinn's books in India. After the show, that jumped to 10,000-15,000 copies a year. The series just changed the game," said Hachette India's Jagoorie.

Even at literature festivals, young readers form a significant share of the audience. "It is particularly encouraging that 65% of our audience is under 35, alongside steadily growing participation from across India, Europe, the Middle East, North America and the global diaspora," said Ravi Deecee, publisher and managing partner of DC Books, and founder of the Kerala Literature Festival.

DRAWING READERS IN

Even as books sell well, the retail base remains smaller than it was pre-covid. "Many stores shut during the pandemic, and some chains restructured. What must be commended is the work put in by the indies—they've strengthened their curation, done in-store events, and found innovative ways to bring readers in," said Jagoorie.

Among the bookstores that had to close temporarily were Full Circle in New Delhi and Idiom in Kochi, although they reopened in other locations. Book store chains such as Crossword and Higginbotham's have since restructured their retail outlets.

Independent bookstores are reinventing themselves. At Atta Galatta, for example, curated programming—book launches, literary meet-ups, magazine-making workshops and even a food-and-literature club—draws steady weekend crowds.

"Simply putting books on shelves isn't enough anymore. We also stage theatre performances in our 100-seater venue. It keeps the space alive and people invested," said Sankar. "Grandparents come in with their Gen Alpha grandchildren, looking for books in Kannada to read to them. Millennial parents make a conscious effort during school holidays and weekends to let their children browse and build a reading habit," she said.

Even for publishers, profitability is being driven by sharper curation, better forecasting and focused marketing rather than sheer volume. "We are not dramatically increasing the number of titles, but are publishing more intentionally, with clearer positioning and longer-term thinking. Overall, the industry has seen mid-single to low-double-digit growth over the past 12-18 months," said Rahul Srivastava, managing director, Bloomsbury India.

"Though revenues are going up, costs of printing, paper and logistics have also risen. It is a price-sensitive space, so we continue to run a tight ship," said Mehra of Rupa Publications. "We manage rising costs by diversifying, making better marketing selections, and gaming the efficiency matrix."

The cost of paper, for example, has gone up from ₹75 to ₹140 a kilo post pandemic, he added.

With books competing against online content, marketing has had to evolve. One size does not fit all. Business titles, for instance, are often marketed via targeted professional and entrepreneurial communities, and on LinkedIn. Literary and popular fiction fare better on Instagram.

"With fragmented attention spans, we need to be more innovative. Book events need to be curated well, based on who and where your core audience is," said Rachna Kalra, founder of WindWord, a book marketing and communications consultancy. Collaborations work well, she added, whether partnering with other authors or moderators who bring their own audiences, or working with specific communities and venues that align organically with the title.

DISCOVERING BOOKS

Another change is how books are discovered: it is now more participatory and community-driven. "While traditional channels like bookstores and literary festivals remain important, a lot of engagement now happens through social media, book clubs, etc. These platforms have become powerful because they create a conversation and connection, rather than just a transactional relationship between reader and book," said Srivastava.

Even though digital content has, in some ways, eaten into reading time, it is also fuelling growth and expanding visibility for a wider range of titles, including literary fiction, translations and niche non-fiction.

Bookstagrammers, book influencers, book clubs and even celebrities are playing an important role in introducing books to new audiences. "Overall, the publishing ecosystem in India has become more vibrant and interconnected, with community-led spaces, festivals and digital platforms complementing traditional discovery channels. Culturally and economically, there is a shift towards more engaged, value-driven reading," said Satti.

From celebrity-led platforms such as Sonali Bendre's Book Club and Twinkle Khanna's Tweak Book Club to thousands of smaller city-based literary collectives, these communities are helping sustain interest—often turning a single recommendation into a broader, longer-term conversation, publishers have found.

Kalra, who set up the Delhi-NCR branch of the Silent Book Club in September 2019 with seven-eight members, recently crossed 1,900 members. "I see many similar book clubs coming up across cities. There is more attention on books today. There are new libraries, too, like the Coforge Public Library in Gurgaon, and book corners at various cafés and cultural spaces," she said.

"With so much heavy news around, readers seem to want something lighter and more comforting. Even in non-fiction, the books that work best are those that offer a clear learning or takeaway, particularly titles written by high-level professionals and corporate leaders," Kalra added.

Another community reading initiative is the Mumbai Literary Club, founded by Bhumika Sankhla and Malliketh Nagda, a management consultant and a banker, respectively, who host a book swap and a book club every month, along with author talks.

"There is a real hunger for book clubs and for being with like-minded people. As reading became lonely during the pandemic, we decided to start a book swap in 2022, where every member would pitch a book to the group, and then everyone picks up a book from the pile," said Nagda.

The club now averages around 40 participants at offline meets, hosted at White Crow Books & Coffee in Jio World Drive.

By all accounts, books are finding new life in India in the digital age, through a younger generation of readers, publishers and authors. A thriving litfest circuit, well-curated bookstores, and reading communities rediscovering the simple pleasures of turning a page bear testament to this heartening reality.

Liked this story? Share it by scanning the QR code.

mint SHORT STORY

WHAT

The publishing industry is enjoying a boom, with sales, exports and readership rising thanks to younger audiences, global interest in Indian authors, and new enthusiasm for print books.

AND

Bookstagrammers, book clubs, literary festivals, translations and community spaces are redefining how books are discovered, turning reading into a participatory cultural activity across India.

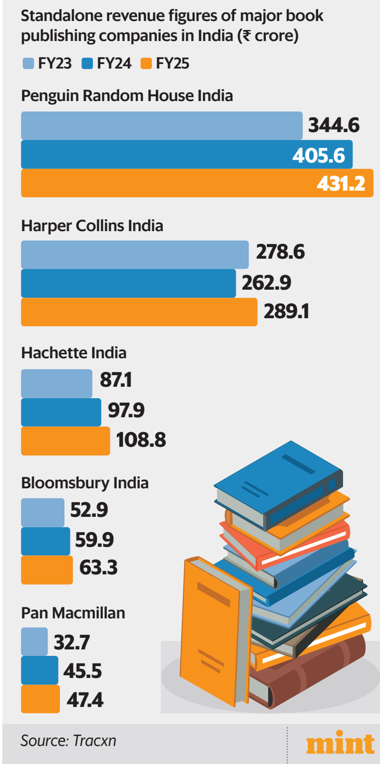
BUT

Bookstore closures during the pandemic reduced retail reach, while paper, printing and logistics costs have put pressure on publishers in a market competing with digital entertainment.

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

PECKING ORDER

Penguin Random House is among the largest English language trade publishers in India.



Source: Tracxn
mint

War, oil spike jolt markets: What should investors do?

Crisis may push up inflation, hurt growth and widen CAD, weighing on rupee and equities

Jash Kriplani
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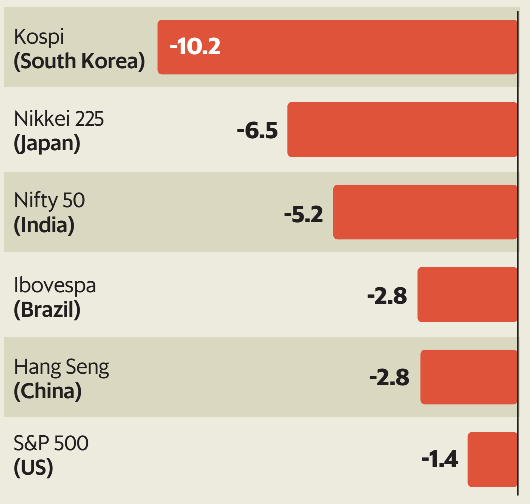
MUMBAI

Investing through war

The US–Israel conflict with Iran has rattled global markets and pushed oil prices higher. While equities have corrected across countries and fund categories, past conflicts show markets often rebound over time.

Recent fall in major country indices since US-Israel war on Iran



In local currency terms, S&P 500 and Ibovespa returns are as of 10 March; other index returns are as of 11 March 2026

How different mutual fund categories have performed

	Returns (in %)			
	Fall since US, Israel, Iran war	1-month	3-month	3-year
Large-cap	-3.6	-5.6	-4.3	15.0
Mid-cap	-3.4	-5.4	-3.2	20.5
Small-cap	-3.3	-6.1	-5.0	17.8
Flexicap	-3.3	-5.5	-4.2	15.4
Multicap	-3.4	-5.7	-4.4	17.7

Source: Value Research; data as of 10 March 2026; mutual fund returns are updated with one-day lag

What experts say

- **Long-term investors** should stay put
- **Don't panic**; avoid knee-jerk reactions
- **Stick to asset allocation**; don't ignore debt, gold
- **Continue SIPs**; gradually deploy if you have cash in hand

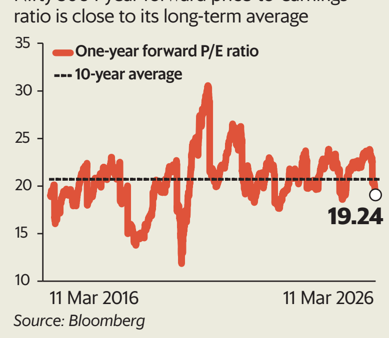
Note: SIPs are systematic investment plans

S&P 500 performance after major geopolitical events

	Start date	% drop to trough	Days to even	1-year return	5-year CAGR	15-year CAGR
World War 2	1 Sep 1939	-33.9%	890	-6.5%	2.6%	6.7%
Yom Kippur War	8 Oct 1973	-43.5%	1,504	-41.1%	-1.2%	6.2%
Russia invades Ukraine	24 Feb 2022	-16.6%	323	-7.4%	N/A	N/A
Israel-Palestine war	9 Oct 2023	-5.0%	19	31.4%	N/A	N/A

Are Indian markets cheaper now

Nifty 50's 1-year forward price-to-earnings ratio is close to its long-term average



Source: Bloomberg

Source: Bloomberg data; for World War 2 and Yom Kippur war, data is sourced from Kaggle - open datasets portal; returns measured from market levels from the event start date or next available market date in case market is closed on that day; CAGR is compounded annual growth rate

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The Nifty 50 has fallen 5.21% between 27 February and 11 March as foreign institutional investors are selling. Brent crude has climbed nearly 26%: from $72.48 to $91.42 a barrel as of 6:30pm IST on 11 March. And the rupee has weakened.

For retail investors who entered the market during the strong rally seen in recent years, portfolio returns are suddenly starting to look volatile. So, what should investors do when geopolitical conflicts—such as the one raging in West Asia—rock the markets?

Oil risk

For India, crude oil is one of the most critical macro variables. India imports nearly 90% of its crude requirement, making it one of the most exposed large economies to global oil price swings. Since the conflict escalated, crude prices have turned sharply volatile.

The real concern for India is not just Iran's oil output of roughly 3-4 million barrels a day, but the threat to the Strait of Hormuz—the narrow waterway through which nearly a fifth of the world's oil supply passes every day. Any disruption there would affect every major oil importer, including India.

That risk is already playing out. Brent crude surged from about $72.48 a barrel on 27 February to an intraday peak of $119.40 on 9 March—a jump of nearly 65% in less than two weeks—before easing to $86–87.

Macro pressures

An oil price spike has huge implications. According to Nilesh Shah, managing director and chief executive Kotak Mutual Fund: "Higher oil price is the *Rahu kaal* of Indian *kundali*. Every 10% jump in oil prices adversely impacts our CPI inflation by 20 bps in primary effect, 10 bps in GDP growth and 10 bps in current account deficit on a back-of-the-envelope calculation. If we take both primary and secondary effects, the hit will almost double. This puts pressure across rupee, rates and equity markets."

"Equity market doesn't like uncertainty. While India is safe from the direct impact of war (no missiles falling in our backyard), Indians are getting impacted. Nine million Indians work in the Gulf. They send billions in remittances," he said. 'Markets will be watching the events to calculate the adverse impact of geopolitical developments."

However, some experts believe the oil price spike may not sustain. "Crude went above $120 in 2022 and then came down to $66. There is ample supply of oil in the world—the primary issue right now is dislocation," said Deepak Shenoy, CEO of Capitalmind Mutual Fund. "Futures markets are showing backwardation, with July-August delivery crude available cheaper than current prices."

History lesson

Despite the volatility, economists remain broadly optimistic about India's economic resilience.

Long-term investors should not panic, said Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at Bank of Baroda. "India's economic fundamentals have not changed because of what is happening in West Asia. For someone with a long-term horizon, this is actually a reasonable time to be buying. FPI selling is more to do with rebalancing global portfolios. It is not a verdict on India."

Historical data also shows oil shocks do not necessarily derail growth.

"Over the past two decades, there have been several episodes of sharp oil price increases. India's GDP growth averaged around 6.2% in the year preceding oil spikes, improved to about 7.2% during the period of rising prices, and moderated slightly to 6.7% in the following year," said Shweta Rajani, head - mutual funds, Anand Rathi Wealth, a wealth management firm. "While higher oil prices create short-term inflationary pressures, the broader economic growth trajectory has historically remained resilient."

Experts advise investors to avoid panic selling and stay invested with diversification across equity, debt and gold

When Germany invaded Poland in September 1939, the S&P 500 fell 33.9% and took 890 trading days to recover, yet by World War II end, in September 1945 it had delivered a 37% return—about 5.4% annually—from war start.

The Yom Kippur War of 1973 caused a 43.5% fall and a 1,504-day recovery. Recent conflicts have seen quicker rebounds: markets fell 16.6% after Russia invaded Ukraine in February 2022 and recovered in 323 trading days, while the Israel-Palestine war in October 2023 brought only a 5% fall, with recovery in 19 trading days, to deliver a 31.4% return in 2024 *(see graphic)*.

Stay invested

Experts advise not to panic sell. "It does not make sense to get out of equities now. You sit out for one to two years, nothing happens. And then, suddenly strong returns may come. Past data also shows returns come to those who stay," Shenoy said.

Research from FundsIndia supports this view. Indian equities have doubled in about 6-7 years around 74% of the time and tripled in about 10–11 years around 81% of the time, highlighting the compounding potential.

A FundsIndia analysis shows markets see temporary declines of 10-20% almost every year, yet close it with positive returns 80% of the time.

Exiting markets during volatility also risks missing the strongest recovery.

An analysis by PGIM India Mutual Fund covering 4 September 2001 to 31 December 2025 showed that investors who stayed fully invested in Nifty 500 TRI earned 17.3% annualised returns. Missing just the 10 best days would have reduced returns to 13.7%. Missing the 30 best days would have cut returns to 8.8%, while missing the 50 best days would have cut returns to just 4.7%.

"Don't sell a quality equity portfolio during a correction unless for any contingency," said Kavitha Menon, founder, Probitus Wealth, a 'fee-only' wealth advisory firm.

"Every serious correction feels like the end. It never is... SIP investors should do nothing. Lump-sum investors with a five-year horizon should see this as an opportunity. The people who will regret this phase are those who stopped investing..." said Dhirendra Kumar, founder of Value Research, an investment advisory firm.

Portfolio reset

Some investors may need to rebalance portfolios. "If it has been heavily skewed towards small- and mid-cap funds or momentum-driven strategies purely to chase returns—that's where the real pain is now," Menon said. This is a signal to reassess, not to panic-sell.

The required action may be less dramatic than what the current anxiety suggests—stay invested in quality portfolios; deploy cash gradually; build a balanced allocation, and if a portfolio fix is needed, start doing it gradually.

Scan the QR code to read an extended version of this story.

When fame outlives life: can an heir inherit personality rights?

Aditya Chopra & Fatima Ali

I am the daughter of a late actress who had a long career in the Indian film industry. Over the years, I have seen individuals and brands use her name, image and likeness without authorization. Can such personality rights be inherited by legal heirs as part of estate planning?

—Name withheld on request

ASK MINT
ESTATE PLAN

Personality rights are a legal safeguard granted to individuals—especially celebrities and public figures—to control the commercialization and use of their name, image, likeness, voice, signature or persona. The justification stems from John Locke's labour theory, which holds that something created through a person's labour and skill rightfully belongs to them, giving the creator the sole right to use it.

Courts have recognized and enforced personality rights of celebrities like Amitabh Bachchan, Anil Kapoor, Aishwarya Rai, Ajay Devgn. This means no individual or entity can piggyback on goodwill or monetize the persona or likeness of these celebrities. The facets of personality rights include the right to protect one's image from unauthorized commercialization, as well as the rights to privacy and publicity. Although the law has recognized the right to privacy as part of Article 21 of the Indian Constitution, the jurisprudential development surrounding it remains limited.

In the context of estate planning, the challenge concerning privacy rights in India is that the Delhi High Court, in Krishna Kishore Singh vs. Sarla A. Saraogi & Ors., CS (COMM) 187/2021, held that posthumous privacy rights are not permissible, implying that such rights are not inheritable upon the demise of a person.

The court also observed that whether personality or publicity rights constitute property forming part of the estate of the deceased, and whether they can be harmonized with the right to privacy, would require the plaintiff to lead evidence establishing that the celebrity's persona has survived as commercial property. It can be concluded that the jurisprudence surrounding posthumous personality rights lies in a grey area, requiring greater clarity from both the legislature and the judiciary. A person who wishes to include the inheritance of personality rights as part of an estate may do so by placing on record evidence of the commercial strength of the individual's persona. However, the possibility of facing challenges while attempting to enforce such rights can't be ruled out.

Aditya Chopra, managing partner, and Fatima Ali, associate, The Victoriam Legalis.

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Compare NRE FD rates

Non-resident Indians (NRIs) can open NRE fixed deposits with different Indian banks. The benefit of an NRE deposit is that it can be opened simply by making inward remittance to India in any freely convertible currency. Another benefit is that the interest earned on NRE deposits are tax-free and the deposit is fully repatriable, allowing NRIs to transfer funds back to their country of residence without restrictions. NRE FDs can be opened and managed online too with Indian banks. NRIs can also obtain loan against NRE FDs which can be used for a variety of purposes. These loans can be granted to the NRI in India or outside India (by overseas branch of Indian banks) or even to third parties.

NRE Term Deposits Interest Rates (%) upto ₹1 crore

	1 to < 2 years	2 to < 3 years	3 to < 5 years	5 years and above
DCB Bank	6.90-7.00	6.90-7.00	7.00-7.10	7.00-7.15
YES Bank	6.65-7.00	6.90-7.00	7.00	6.75
RBL Bank	7.00-7.20	7.20	7.00-7.20	6.70
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	6.70-6.75	6.75-7.25	6.65	6.60
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	6.60-7.10	6.60	6.60	6.60
IndusInd Bank	6.75-7.00	6.90	6.65-6.90	6.50-6.65
Dhanlaxmi Bank	6.25-6.95	6.25-6.50	6.50-7.00	6.50-6.60
ICICI Bank	6.25-6.30	6.30-6.45	6.45-6.50	6.50
Axis Bank	6.25-6.45	6.45	6.45	6.45
Federal Bank	6.25-6.50	6.40	6.40-6.70	6.40
City Union Bank	6.60-7.10	6.60	6.30-6.60	6.30
Karur Vysya Bank	6.55-6.80	6.55	6.55	6.25-6.55
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.50-6.70	6.70	6.40	6.25
Canara Bank	6.25-6.50	6.25	6.25	6.25
HDFC Bank	6.25-6.45	6.45	6.40-6.50	6.15-6.40
Indian Overseas Bank	6.40-6.60	6.40	6.10	6.10

Data taken from respective bank's website as on 10 Mar 2026; Only main entity of the merged banks are taken. Banks which merged with its main entity are removed from the table; The list of 16 banks is based on highest fixed deposit rates available for 5 years and above.

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

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Source: BankBazaar

WHEN A GIFT DEED ISN'T FOREVER: HOW SENIOR CITIZENS CAN RECLAIM PROPERTY

POWER POINT

SHRADDHA NILESHWAR

Respond to this column at
feedback@livemint.com

Senior citizens increasingly find themselves in court, fighting to reclaim homes they once "gifted" to their children or daughters-in-law during family settlements or estate planning, while heirs insist that "a gift is forever". Under the Indian Transfer of Property Act, 1882, a gift is generally irrevocable once properly executed and registered, unless it carries a valid, agreed contingency for revocation under Section 126.

Recent Supreme Court rulings confirm that if a gift deed is absolute and doesn't include a revocation clause, the donor (the person gifting) cannot cancel it on their own at a later stage. However, heirs often mistakenly assume that once a gift is registered, the parents have signed away their rights forever under all circumstances, which isn't the case.

Under Section 23 of the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007, a senior citizen can legally cancel a property transfer (like a gift) before the relevant tribunal or authority if two things are true: they gave the property with the understanding that the receiver would care for them, and the receiver has since failed to provide basic care or amenities. Courts interpret this provision with intent in mind while examining surrounding circumstances. If neglect follows the transfer, they may treat it as involving fraud or undue influence and revoke the gift.

In a landmark Bombay High Court ruling in Dilip Manohar Wagh Vs. Sub-Divisional Officer (writ petition decided on 12 June 2018), Justices Ranjit More and Anuja Prabhudessai upheld the revocation of a gift deed under the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act after examining the surrounding facts carefully. In that case, a widowed father, pressured by his son before a second marriage, gifted 50% of his flat to "protect" the son's interests within the family arrangement. Once the transfer was done, the son and daughter-in-law began harassing him and refused to support his second wife.

The maintenance tribunal annulled the gift and restored full ownership to the father, and the high court upheld this after reviewing the evidence on record, treating the promise to maintain both spouses as an implied condition embedded in the transaction. The message to entitled heirs was blunt: "you cannot weaponize a gift deed to first extract property and then discard the parent".

Similarly, the case of Smt. Varindar Kaur Vs. Smt. Daljit Kaur (decided on 26 September 2025) revolved around an 88-year-old woman who had gifted property to her daughter-in-law and succeeded in getting the gift cancelled through proceedings under the senior citizens law after she showed neglect, mistreatment and denial of basic care. The high court highlighted that when a senior citizen gifts property within the family, an implied expectation of care accompanies the document even if the deed is silent about such conditions in writing.

Why does the revocation clause matter?

These cases expose a divergence: on paper, a gift without a revocation clause is nearly bulletproof under traditional property law principles. In reality, though, senior-citizen-specific law is carving out humanitarian exceptions to protect vulnerable elderly donors. A well-drafted revocation clause addressing non-maintenance, abuse, or alienation of property without consent can significantly reduce future disputes by converting moral expectations into enforceable conditions. It also forces the receivers to understand, at the time of signing the gift deed document, that their continued enjoyment of the property is contingent on how they treat the donor after the transfer takes effect.

At the same time, courts have cautioned that individuals cannot retro-fit a revocation right where none was reserved; attempts at unilateral cancellation in such cases routinely fail.

Careful legal drafting is crucial when you decide to gift property to family members

Thoughtful drafting therefore becomes the first line of defence: recording clear triggers for revocation, aligning them with statutory limits, and dovetailing the gift with maintenance arrangements, whether by contract, promissory note, or specific recitals can dramatically shift the balance of power back towards vulnerable parents. In the new battlefield between senior citizens and entitled heirs, the fine print of the gift deed is fast becoming as important as the property itself.

As advisors, we approach such situations with caution. If an individual, especially a senior citizen, wishes to gift property to loved ones, we must first ensure that they retain sufficient financial security. Their livelihood and independence should remain fully protected even after giving the gift. It is therefore essential for individuals to consult qualified professionals to fully understand the nuances of this topic, which may seem simple on the surface but is far more complex in practice.

Shraddha Nileshwar is head, will and estate planning, 1 Finance.

OUR VIEW

ISTOCKPHOTO

Maximize inflows of FDI but run a security check

Easing investment from border-sharing countries could revive Chinese interest and serve India's export ambitions but let's keep electronic components under watch for hidden risks

It is welcome that India is liberalizing inward investment from countries that share a land border with India. Investments up to 10% of a company's paid-up capital that involve no board-seat control will be allowed under the automatic route. Investment proposals that need government approval would also be fast-tracked for nods within 60 days in specified sectors, including the manufacture of capital goods, capital goods for electronics, electronic components, polysilicon and the conversion of polysilicon into ingots and their slicing into wafers. A precondition is that the investee company should be majority owned and controlled by Indians or Indian entities. The move eases curbs imposed back in 2020 and signals a lower guard against the role played by Chinese capital in India's economy. In general, a policy tweak that aims to maximize foreign inflows is good for GDP growth and job creation. For us to join global value chains, the colour of money should matter less than what it can do for us. However, in today's times, investment, technology and national security are interlinked. Many countries, the US included, no longer allow Chinese gear in their core telecom networks even though it is both effective and economical. Such caution must apply to some electronic components as well.

Every such component is not amenable to remote control by its maker and exposed to the risk of being turned against our interests. Those that are should be kept strictly indigenous in design and production; drone control units are an example. Complex electronic equipment is assembled from simpler parts that are not vulnerable to foreign misuse or sabotage. We should not hesitate to invite equity partners from abroad to produce such components at scale in India. But when it comes to sub-assemblies and assemblies, the picture changes. Only a firm grasp of their technological intricacy and openness to being disabled or hijacked should determine whether making them locally with foreign capital or tech participation would compromise national security or not. It is vital to develop this nous and bring it to bear on investment decisions in sensitive fields.

Although India has forged closer ties with many countries, only Russia has been willing to share critical technologies with us without holding anything back—as with cryogenic rocket engine blueprints. However, the past is no guarantee of future performance. We should strive for integration with supply chains that involve electronics and an easier inward path for foreign direct investment (FDI) can aid that effort. Indeed, it is vital for export success. However, for domestic deployment, particularly in vital sectors that have a bearing on national security—such as our power grid, telecom networks and defence equipment—we should bar automatic procurement from such export-oriented value chains. We must invest heavily in R&D, even 'reinvent the wheel' if necessary, to master crucial production processes and technologies, even if these are available cheaper from abroad. We need a programme set up to identify key areas of national security concern, equipment deployed in them, their components and their potential vulnerability, even as we liberalize FDI rules for an export thrust. Technology licensing must be counted as a form of absolute control, more binding than majority ownership, when it comes to the security vetting of investment proposals. Subject to such safeguards, we should let as much FDI in as possible. We have been running short.

MY VIEW | MYTHS AND MANTRAS

Wars and their market impact: What the historical record says

The history of conflicts would suggest that shaken stock markets don't take long to regain normalcy

DEVINA MEHRA
is founder of First Global and author of 'Money, Myths and Mantras: The Ultimate Investment Guide'. Her X handle is @devinamehra

These are sombre times for the world. The big conflict in West Asia is giving everyone the jitters. For readers of a business paper, the main questions would be related to its impact on markets. Before coming to that, here's a bit of a background with the caveat that I am not a geopolitics expert. Nevertheless, what I have done is look at history, facts and data.

As I had pointed out in January in an interview, Iran is not a small country. It is more than half the area of India. And if you strike Iran, there will be adverse consequences. It is not a country you can overpower very easily. It has an arsenal. It has military forces. And probably more of a stomach to take casualties than the US alliance does. Moreover, Iran's geography—with mountains and salt deserts—is such that ground warfare is nearly impossible.

I, for one, never understood what the end game of the US-Israeli strikes was. This is not the place to go into the details of why regime change is almost impossible with current tactics.

On the other hand, Iran has been strategic in its chess game by striking economically. The cost of neutralizing an inexpensive drone is orders of magnitude higher. But it has also been working to increase the risk perception of the region and make the economic cost of the war prohibitive. It did not need to close the Strait of Hormuz, just make ship passage uninsurable. Plus, Iran has managed to shake the 'safe haven' image of US allies in the region. Possibly, its game is to get the Gulf countries to pressure the US to stop the conflict. Those appear to be Tehran's objectives, and to an extent, I would say that they have succeeded.

Coming to financial markets, we did this study just before the Russia-Ukraine war started in 2022. We went back over 50 years and looked at every single major geopolitical event: the two Gulf Wars, Afghanistan, 9/11, the US bombing Libya, etc. And what we found was that in every case, there was turmoil in stock markets just before and after the incident, but in six months to one year, markets had forgotten about the disruption.

We did not have enough data points for a statistical study, but the exercise did not need to be statistical because the same thing happened each time. I could not find an exception to the rule. At times, there was some residual impact on commodities, but not on stock markets. The only markets impacted a year later were those hit directly by the conflict.

On the other hand, conflicts themselves don't get resolved that easily. Even when the adversaries were completely mis-matched, as with the US versus Vietnam or versus Afghanistan, the bigger guy could not win even after seven years and 20 years respectively.

If you focus narrowly on markets, wars have historically not impacted them beyond a little at the start. That's also what we saw with Russia-Ukraine, even though the war continues four years later. Six months after the start of that war, I remember headlines in Indian newspapers that the market had forgotten about it.

While we had done the exercise going back a little over five decades, a recent piece in *Financial Times* entitled, 'On ignoring geopolitics, buying bubbles and hoarding gold' went back over a century and included the two World Wars which killed tens of millions of people, only to come to the same conclusion: that it is not worthwhile selling out due to geopolitical upheavals.

The big dislocations in markets have not been due to geopolitics. Extreme crashes were due to other reasons, from the 1929 Great Depression to the 2000 tech crash to the 2008 financial crisis.

As far as oil is concerned, let me tell you what we did on oil a few weeks ago. It was not a call that this conflict would break out. However, looking at the trajectory of oil prices at the time, it appeared to us that the risk-reward equation was in our favour in terms of oil going up. Around the beginning of February, we further underweighted US equities and increased the commodity exposure of our Global multi-asset fund.

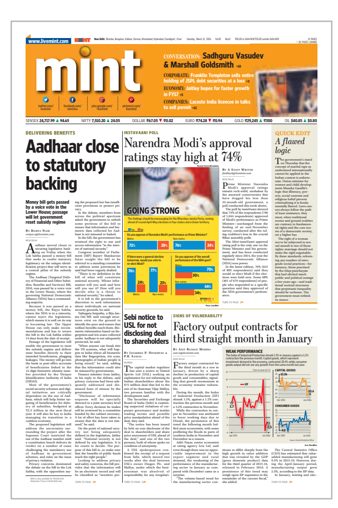
Nevertheless, we know that every time there is a conflict in the Gulf, oil prices go up. But remember that no one wants the flow of oil to stop. Whether it's an old ruler, a new ruler or an invader, everyone wants the crude oil trade to continue. That is the region's cash cow. Whether it is Saddam Hussein or the ISIS, nobody disrupts oil flows beyond a point. We can all guess that the US would not be too interested in Iran (or Venezuela) if the latter was not a major oil producer. In other words, everyone is there for the oil.

This time, there has been a little more of a supply squeeze on oil, although the US has reportedly shown displeasure over Israel's targeting of Iran's oil facilities, which suggests that America does not want such damage inflicted.

Leaving aside the humanitarian questions that every war raises, as far as the stock markets are concerned, going by history, I do not expect any significant lasting impact of the latest flare-up.

Crude was anyway expected to rise a bit and you might see some news-driven gyrations there, but eventually it will settle down to a more normal—albeit perhaps an upward—trajectory. Also remember, we did live with $100-plus oil around 15 years ago, that too in the middle of a global recession. So even that is not the end of the world.

10 YEARS AGO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DELIVERING BENEFITS
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Money bill gets passed by a voice vote in the Lower House; passage will let government reset subsidy regime

INSTAVAANI POLL
Narendra Modi's approval ratings stay high at 74%
GOING STRONG

QUICK EDIT
A flawed logic

Sebi notice to USL for not disclosing deal to shareholders

SIGNS OF VULNERABILITY
Factory output contracts for third straight month in January
WEAK PERFORMANCE

JUST A THOUGHT

Allowing limited Chinese participation in India's manufacturing ecosystem could make it easier for [multinational] companies to shift final assembly to India while maintaining access to Chinese inputs.

ARPIT CHATURVEDI

MY VIEW | WORLD APART

Can any good come of this appalling war in West Asia?

RAHUL JACOB

is a former Financial Times foreign correspondent.

If proof were needed that even after decades of globalization, the world isn't flat, Iran's chokehold over the Strait of Hormuz is providing plenty. The opposing view might be summarized in four words, 'The Revenge of Geography,' the title of geopolitical analyst Robert Kaplan's prescient book more than a decade ago. "Terrain determines the pace and method of fighting... the flat deserts of Kuwait and Iraq in the Gulf War of 1991 magnified the effect of air power, even as holding vast and heavily populated stretches of Iraq in the Second Gulf War showed the limits of air power and thus made American (ground) forces victims of geography," Kaplan wrote, "Aircraft can bombard, but they cannot transport goods in bulk, nor exercise control on the ground."

As they embarked on the Third Gulf War, the US and Israel appear to have assumed their vastly superior air power and military intelligence would end the war in days. Iran, in response, launched drone attacks on US allies around the region in a bid to globalize the war and force the US and Israel to relent.

Assuming some sort of strategic plan precedes war in today's world of majoritarian populists, the US-Israeli assumption appears to have been that with the senior Iran leadership killed, an acquiescent new leader in Tehran would capitulate, as in Venezuela. The recent 'election' of Ayatollah Khamenei's son as supreme leader suggests the hardline faction is still in charge. Now a war of attrition begins as the US and Israel seek to destroy Iranian infrastructure and Tehran responds by using drones and the proximity of geography to continue attacks on other oil and gas producers to make the global economy suffer collateral damage. US and Israeli casualties have been a fraction of those incurred by Iran. The bombing of an Iranian school and torpedoing of a naval ship off the coast of Sri Lanka each left vastly more people dead than the total casualties on the other side.

Are there any bright spots amid the horrors of war? The first is that if and when financial markets start to really tumble, the guiding principle of today's rule-by-chaos US administration may come into play: Trump (almost) Always Chickens Out. On the other side, Iran's leadership, unlike Ukraine's much more popular leadership when Russia attacked it four years ago, may come under domestic pressure to end the war. Iran's strategy of attacking its Gulf neighbours also looks set to backfire as they might cooperate more closely with the US and push for regime change in Tehran.

Two unintended consequences appear likely. One is that India and other Asian countries will build larger buffers of oil reserves. Japan and Korea have strategic oil reserves that should allow them to manage for half a year or so. Nevertheless, the Seoul stock index plunged as the war began before the Korean government stepped in to bolster it. It is in the interest of governments everywhere to put on a business-as-usual face. Markets are volatile but following suit; Brent crude oil futures descended after a brief scare earlier this week.

Perhaps an oil shock will arrest complacency on climate change and push us to decarbonize our economies

So far, so relatively sanguine. Yet, even as the Saudis and others find ways to transport oil through pipelines and other routes, the longer Iran's Hormuz stranglehold continues, oil price pressure will grow. As Windward, a research consultancy, observed in an update this week: "The mechanisms suppressing traffic are no longer purely kinetic. The combination of vessel attacks, elevated strike risk, GPS and AIS (Automatic Identification System) interference, and the withdrawal of insurable war-risk coverage is now producing a *de facto* closure effect for much of the commercial market, despite the absence of a formally declared and universally enforced blockade."

After four weeks of this, we could be in a different psychological zone altogether. Many oil tanker crews will have returned and many oil producers would have long exhausted their storage capacity. *The Wall Street Journal* points out, "As Yemen's Houthis have shown with their attacks in the Red Sea, it doesn't take much sophistication to close major international shipping lanes. With a few drones and anti-ship missiles, the Iranians could do that too for a long time." Since 2022, Iran's increased capacity to make Shahed kamikaze drones, and transfer the tech to Russia, has been a critical factor in that conflict and may prolong this one, too.

A happier prospect is that this oil shock might arrest today's complacency on climate change and push the world to decarbonize faster. As the global energy consultancy Wood Mackenzie forecast last year, demand for liquid hydrocarbons is expected to rise for another half dozen years. Natural gas demand will remain 'resilient' through the 2040s, the report predicts.

Two alternative paths have been laid out by our neighbours, one predictable, the other less so. In China, oil demand looks set to fall by a third in three decades thanks to rapid electric vehicle adoption, said the report: "However, India, Southeast Asia and Africa remain key drivers of oil demand growth." The other salutary example is Sri Lanka. In response to its economic crisis a few years ago that required an IMF bailout, the country is now reliant on renewables for 70% of its electricity, compared with less than 50% in 2021. By contrast, while renewables account for over half of India's power generation capacity, their share of our energy consumption is a mere 15-20%.

There are many reasons to decry this appalling war, but perhaps some good will come of it. As an expert quipped, it is hard to weaponize solar and wind energy.

MY VIEW | ACUTE ANGLE

Anthropic's warning shot about surveillance demands attention

AI enables the state to surveil citizens at a massive scale. This raises serious questions of privacy, freedom and dissidence

SANJOY CHAKRAVORTY
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Late last month, the US Department of War labelled Anthropic, creator of the artificial intelligence (AI) system Claude, "a supply chain risk," and began taking steps to remove it from all use in the department, including by contractors and subcontractors to its roughly $1 trillion annual spending. There are news reports that no company that does work with the Pentagon will be allowed to engage in "commercial activity" with Anthropic. President Donald Trump called Anthropic a "radical left, woke company" that he "fired... like dogs."

OpenAI, the creator of ChatGPT and leading system in the AI race, swooped in within a day. It is Anthropic's main rival and both companies are far ahead of challengers like Alphabet, DeepSeek, Meta and Microsoft. Anthropic is estimated to lose about $200 million in direct contracts. Its preference for the public good over private gain is widely viewed as a heroic, almost quixotic, act.

Why did matters come to this head? In a public statement, Dario Amodei, CEO and co-founder of Anthropic, said it is because Anthropic demanded two safeguards in using its product. One, that it should not be used for mass surveillance against Americans. Two, it should not be deployed for fully autonomous weapons. Amodei's own words are worth quoting at length because they summarize the argument best.

First: "AI-driven mass surveillance presents serious, novel risks to our fundamental liberties... Under current law, the government can purchase detailed records of Americans' movements, web browsing, and associations from public sources without obtaining a warrant... Powerful AI makes it possible to assemble this scattered, individually innocuous data into a comprehensive picture of any person's life—automatically and at massive scale." Today's column focuses on this issue.

Second: "Fully autonomous weapons (those that take humans out of the loop entirely and automate selecting and engaging targets) may prove critical for our national defense. But today, frontier AI systems are simply not reliable enough to power fully autonomous weapons... without proper oversight, fully autonomous weapons cannot be relied upon to exercise the critical judgment that [trained professionals] exhibit every day. They need to be deployed with proper guardrails, which don't exist today." This is a frightening prospect, especially given that makers of AI systems themselves do not understand how their systems make choices. This subject deserves a separate discussion.

The issue of mass surveillance and erosion of individual privacy by the state is one that has become increasingly urgent, almost in lock-step with the digitalization of information. The discourse is distressingly familiar. According to the state, there are rising threats from terrorists, bad actors, rogue nations, hostile governments and "the enemy within." To keep its 'good' citizens safe from these threats, the state asks (in not so many words) for a tradeoff: give up some individual rights (especially on privacy) to get more security.

Critical security theorists call this approach 'securitization,' implying that security threats are socially constructed. The state creates narratives of fear ("only we can save you") that are mostly bogus to enlarge its power to jail opponents or dissidents and curb civil liberties. The so-called 'war on terror' in the US after the 9/11 attacks led to 'enhanced interrogation' of unlawfully detained individuals, the Patriot Act and large-scale warrantless wiretapping by units like the National Security Agency to ostensibly identify 'terrorists' among the populace.

In India, digital tools have already massively expanded the state's armoury of surveillance and control. Some attempts have failed. For example, the ham-handed effort to mandate a state-run cybersecurity app on phones (Sanchar Saathi). Others have been scandalous, such as the alleged use of Pegasus spyware to surveil journalists and political opponents. Other ongoing efforts have been far more successful, especially the use of the Aadhaar system for large-scale data collection.

Yet, many other efforts are generally under-recognized, often covert and almost always with no public oversight. Laws such as the Telecommunications Act and Digital Personal Data Protection Act (both from 2023) are meant to safeguard the interests of data users. Perhaps they do, but they also empower the state over individual privacy in the guise of security. The state uses its Central Monitoring System to monitor communication across mobile, landline and internet platforms, and Network Traffic Analysis to surveil emails, social media posts and Voice over Internet Protocol calls, apart from facial recognition technologies and drone surveillance in public spaces.

Amodei warns that AI can be used to stitch this "scattered, individually innocuous data into a comprehensive picture of any person's life—automatically and at massive scale." This is not a sci-fi fantasy. The Chinese state is already using AI to systematize data, a project fed by 700 million cameras, biometrics, facial recognition, voice identification, ID cards, WeChat, Alipay, e-commerce, medical records, hotel stays and so on. But that is China, a regime like no other, governing a citizenry that has never had individual freedom of the sort that India, the US and most of Europe are justifiably proud of.

The Indian state, however, has a relatively dubious record on handling dissidence. A sedition law designed by the colonial state was used to jail figures such as Mahatma Gandhi and Bal Gangadhar Tilak. The Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita retains a provision to punish sedition (even though the word has been dropped), while the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act continues to be used to jail activists; think of the cases of Umar Khalid, Disha Ravi and Kanhaiya Kumar.

The use of AI for mass surveillance is a temptation for all 'securitized' states, India included. How far the Indian state has already gone with AI use on its massive data collection and how much further it will go are not known. It may be necessary to begin thinking now about ways for civil society to monitor the Indian state's use of AI (itself improving by leaps and bounds) as it grants officials unprecedented power to surveil the thoughts and behaviours of citizens.

MINT CURATOR

From bidets to AI labs: Japan's firms must stop being modest

They should learn the art of hype for the world to notice their tech

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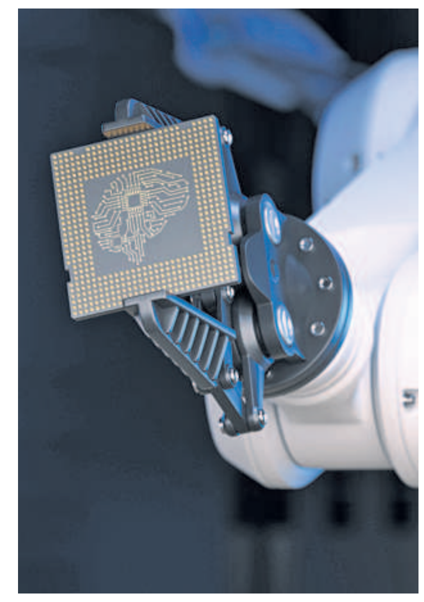

Japanese firms often struggle to tell their success stories. ISTOCKPHOTO

A Japanese maker of high-tech toilets has been causing a splash in the world of artificial intelligence (AI). Activist investor Palliser Capital recently called on the management of Toto, best known for its Washlet bidets, to highlight that the firm is a growing AI play, thanks to its advanced ceramics segments. Toto is the "most undervalued and overlooked AI memory beneficiary," Palliser wrote. Its little-known business of chip parts recently accounted for half its operating profit. Yet, just a page was dedicated to it in the most recent investor presentation, with this limited disclosure leaving its value "effectively hidden from the market," the fund said.

Palliser has a point here—and it's one that extends beyond the porcelain throne.

Japanese firms often struggle to tell their success stories, particularly if they're diversified or in niche industries. Carefully stage-managed domestic media engagements tend to dominate. While disclosure is improving, getting information out of some firms can still be akin to pulling teeth. Worse, for years even companies that were proactive often found it hard to reach a receptive audience.

But things are changing in the era of AI and robotics, where Japan has vast expertise in specialty chemicals and wafer substrates, sensors and motors. The country might have fallen behind in the age of software, but these physical hardware supply chains are exactly the kind of industries where firms still have an edge.

While some bemoan the lack of 'creative destruction' in the economy, innovation happens differently. Like Toto, companies reinvent themselves with alacrity and transition to new business models.

Take Fujikura. It was founded in 1885, the age of steam engines and gas lamps, but is now one of the world's hottest AI bets thanks to its optical fibres used in data centres. Shares have risen almost 25 times since the start of 2024, the best-performing Japanese blue-chip.

Or Nitto Boseki, which began as a silk-spinning firm in 1898, the year H.G. Wells published *The War of the Worlds*. It's now a leading supplier of glass cloth fibre, with its stock more than quadrupling since last year amid reports of its links to Nvidia and Apple. Printers Dai Nippon Printing (founded 1876) and Toppan (dating to 1900) might be associated with ink and paper, but are actually crucial makers of chip packaging materials and photomasks.

Yamaha is the subject of memes about its diverse output. It makes musical keyboards and pianos, even if it is mostly seen as a motorbike maker. The diversification continues: Yamaha aims to expand its own semiconductor backend business into a ¥100 billion ($633 million) earner by the 2030s.

I have had more than one conversation in recent weeks with people surprised to learn that Japan is the world leader in industrial robots, with a 70% market share according to the trade and industry ministry. But even I was unaware until recently that Omron, a company that most think of as making healthcare devices like thermometers and weighing scales, now makes two-thirds of its profits from industrial automation.

Despite this dominance, robotic tech is increasingly associated with China's flashy-yet-impractical kung-fu fighting humanoid automatons and Tesla's overhyped Optimus robots. This is where Japan must get better at promoting itself.

The advent of high-quality AI translation tools that make company materials understandable for anyone has helped. But in any language, you would struggle to learn much about one of the country's biggest companies in this sector, the notoriously secretive Keyence. Shares of this maker of sensors for automating factories have been range-bound for five years, even as sales and profits have doubled. It would surely benefit from a little over-the-top robotics hype.

Japanese products tend to become world famous only after they get a little help from abroad. The movie *Lost in Translation* is often credited with awakening the world to Japanese whisky; a handful of Australian skiers first realized the potential of Hokkaido's now-famous powder snow. The government is currently trying to turn anime into a major export business, but it became globally famous not because of a top-down push, but by bottom-up fandom on pirate sites like Crunchyroll, founded by a group of Americans.

Japanese companies need evangelists. Palliser says rewriting the narrative could add another 55% to Toto's shares. Some people in Tokyo have been getting a little uncomfortable with the growing power of activists, but these are the folks who could help spread the word.

In the original gold rush, it was all about picks and shovels. This time, it's more about the plumbing.

GUEST VIEW

India must act before the coming AI-pocalypse kicks in

ASHISH DHAWAN & PIYUSH DOSHI

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As the dust settles on India's recent AI summit—optimistic in tone, ambitious in scope—a harder question demands an honest answer. What does the next wave of artificial intelligence mean for a sector that has served as a key economic engine for three decades? Information technology (IT) services generate over $254 billion in annual exports, employ 5.4 million professionals and finance a merchandise trade deficit that has breached $300 billion.

Software exports are a success story. They are also a macroeconomic stabilizer, rupee backstop and social contract (given their role in expanding India's middle class). This engine is under threat as Agentic AI systems deployed at scale by Anthropic, OpenAI, Google and Microsoft can autonomously write code, manage workflows, process claims and run structured business processes. Much of India's IT sector's services fall in this category. Niti Aayog warns that our tech-sector headcount could fall from 7.5 million to 6 million by 2031. The stock market has voted: India's IT majors have seen their share prices fall while their global counterparts surged. A sharp slowdown in IT exports can precipitate a collapse of the rupee, forcing up interest rates and pushing the Centre to cut expenditure, which would put further pressure on growth and jobs.

If there's a silver lining, it is the possibility of a broad manufacturing renaissance. India accounts for just 2.9% of global factory output and 1.8% of goods exports—a share that has barely moved in two decades. Manufacturing contributes just 13% of GDP, against 25-32% in East Asian countries that exhibited miracle growth. The gap between India's potential and performance reflects not so much a market failure as a policy failure waiting to be corrected.

Paradoxically, a weaker rupee could become an asset. It would serve exports well, giving Indian merchandise a price edge just as global supply chains seek to diversify beyond China.

India's production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme has seen electronics production surge 146% since 2020-21, even as mobile exports have grown 8-fold. Our National Manufacturing Mission could convert this proof of concept into a structural shift in favour of the factory sector. Here is how:

First, a global value chain taskforce should identify the top 20 global firms across priority sectors—electronics, EVs, semiconductors, defence, chemicals and medical devices—and pursue them with a whatever-it-takes mandate: bespoke incentives, coordinated Centre-state action and 90-day decision cycles. Apple's move to India catalysed billions in investment and made us the world's second-largest mobile phone maker. The lesson: a few strategic anchors can transform a field.

Our IT services success story is reaching its limits and we must aim for a manufacturing renaissance

Second, ease import bottlenecks. High tariffs on base metals, speciality chemicals, capital goods and components protect upstream producers but also price downstream exporters out of global markets. A surgical audit of input costs across the top export value chains, followed by tariff rationalization and faster customs clearances, would restore competitiveness better than a weaker exchange rate.

Third, 'Gift cities' for manufacturing. Less than 2% of India's land is used for industry. Manufacturers, particularly small businesses. struggle to find suitable sites that are cleared and connected. States must develop industrial clusters where land is pre-acquired and titled, utility connections are in place, building bye-laws are liberal and approvals are delegated to local authorities offering truly single-window clearances. These clusters should be modelled on the Gift City framework, where meaningfully differential regulation can be applied on par with the world's most liberal.

Fourth, PLI 1.0 has given India a clear set of lessons. It has attracted over ₹2 trillion in investments across 14 sectors and helped transform electronics and pharmaceuticals. We now need PLI 2.0, which should be more ambitious in its targets. It should anchor the National Manufacturing Mission's goal of this sector accounting for 25% of GDP and be simpler in design: fewer sectors pursued with greater depth, and with streamlined eligibility and faster disbursement cycles. PLI 2.0 must operate with a dedicated secretariat and measurable quarterly milestones with full accountability.

Fifth, India must deregulate quickly. It has made genuine progress on this front through dedicated taskforces recently. But much still needs to be done before we can claim parity with frictionless investment destinations like China, Vietnam and other Asian countries. The immediate priority is to sharply reduce licence and compliance requirements, consolidate overlapping regulatory jurisdictions, digitize inspections with time-bound outcomes and enforce accountability for delays.

While these five measures can get our manufacturing engine going, it will require a few more reforms to sustain. We must tackle the issue of electricity cross-subsidization to ensure that Indian companies have access to reliable power at competitive rates. Similarly, GST and labour code simplification should go further, so our labour market and tax administration are on par with the best. Finally, we need a strong dispute resolution mechanism with dedicated commercial courts, mandatory pre-litigation mediation and specialist arbitration to reduce the risk premium that investors price into every decision.

India has missed the manufacturing bus before. The next one is boarding. We must spare no effort to get a ticket.